

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 20 SEPTEMBER 2026 · THE SUNDAY EDITION



TWO AND A HALF HOURS FROM CHANGI, AND THE PERMIT NUMBER ALMOST EVERY GUIDE PRINTS IS FOUR YEARS OUT OF DATE (**P21**)

THE TRAVEL DESK

Sabah: the animals are easy to see because the forest is a ribbon, and seventy-eight per cent of the reserve is plantation

THE RABBIT HOLE

Hand-tool woodworking, all the way down — and the sceptic inside it who calls the whole culture virtue signalling

THE ATELIER

Every tooth of a moulded comb carries a ridge where the mould halves met — and the comb without one costs four pounds fifty

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: Wikimedia Commons — climbers on the summit trail of Mount Kinabalu, Sabah, at sunrise. The mountain on **p22**; a fit twelve-year-old is well inside the norm for it.

THIS ISSUE • THE SUNDAY EDITION • NO. 108

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FROM THE DESK

“A man with a watch knows what time it is. A man with two watches is never sure.”

Known as Segal’s law; the attribution has never been traced to a source, and the line is best treated as an anonymous mid-twentieth-century proverb

An issue of second watches. Two prices for one e-reader. And a benchmark mean that averaged away the two scores that mattered.

THE STRIP • AT FRIDAY’S CLOSE

US 10-year	4.997%	▲ +6bp
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,383.45	▲ +0.97%
Bitcoin	~\$81,000	▲ 2-week high
Brent crude (Nov)	\$103.87	▼ -0.91%
USD/SGD	1.2762	± flat
VWRA (All-World)	\$191.66	▼ -1.03% wk
AGGU (global agg)	\$5.76	± flat wk
STI	5,656.11	▼ -0.08%
USD/JPY	156.87	▲ +1.2% wk

Treasury yields on the par curve. Two corrections to our own record, and the bitcoin print as a range, on **p14**. Not advice.¹

FROM THE ARCHIVE • THE SECOND WATCH, THREE TIMES OVER

No. 107 found the narrow part. A strait, a burr, a sizing agent. This issue is its mirror: not the small thing that governs everything, but the big summary number that governs nothing, because the disagreement inside it has already been divided out. — **p8, p12, p18**

And a receipt on last week’s. No. 106 printed the Straits Times Index at 5,660.52 as Friday’s close and the US ten-year at 4.951 per cent, down five basis points. The first was *Thursday’s* close; the second an Asia-hours print, against a US settlement of 4.997, up six. Both corrected on **p14**, where the held VWRA print is released.

SOURCES 1 Levels at Friday’s close, 18 September 2026; Treasury yields from the US par curve, the rest from exchange and listings data read at source on 19 September, with the Straits Times Index cross-checked on two services. Gold is spot and is **not** a record — the all-time high remains US\$5,608.35, set in January 2026. The corrections above are to this publication’s own No. 106 and are set out with sources on **p14**.

THE WORLD · THE GULF, WEEK FOUR

Europe's October is zero. The oil price fell anyway

Aramco has told its European term customers there will be no Saudi crude for them next month. In the same week it sold sixty million barrels out of Ras Tanura — east, through the strait everyone calls closed.

The barrels did not stop. They changed address.

After drones took out pumping stations on the East–West pipeline on 10–11 September, Saudi Aramco told European term customers they would receive nothing in October — every European term buyer, at least two of them told their allocation is zero. There has been no declaration of force majeure.¹ Poland's Orlen has issued more than ten tenders since Friday hunting replacements; European OECD members took an average of 577,000 barrels a day of Saudi crude in June.¹

In the same days Aramco sold roughly sixty million barrels out of Ras Tanura — one to one and a half million a day put back into the market, through the waterway described as shut since February.¹ Europe's cargoes went east. That is why Brent fell to **US\$103.87** on Friday, down 0.9 per cent and a third straight session lower.²

Read the traffic count carefully, because it is the number that will be quoted at you all week. The IMF's PortWatch recorded **eight** transits of Hormuz on 13 September against a baseline near eighty-five a day.² Saudi volumes through the same strait roughly *doubled* over the same period, to more than two million barrels a day.¹ Both are true, because the hulls carrying the difference have their transponders off: ninety-eight of 243 screened tankers went dark in a day, against a weekly average of 49.5.² A published transit count is a floor. It was never a total.

TEHRAN IRGC NAVY, VIA SEPAH NEWS, 18 SEP

The force says it struck the Togo-flagged product tanker *Trend* on the night of the seventeenth for crossing without Iranian permission. The vessel had been “deceived and provoked” by the US Army, and an illegal passage “will lead to nothing but ‘destruction.’”³

LONDON UK MARITIME TRADE OPERATIONS, 17 SEP

The UKMTO log for the same night records an incident sixteen miles north-east of Khasab, Oman: a tanker struck by an “unknown projectile,” fire extinguished, “the crew were safe.” No attribution to Iran, and no agency has identified the *Trend* as the vessel.³ One capital publishes deterrence; the other a casualty report.

THE CHATTER · THE PREMIUM MOVED ONTO THE BALANCE SHEET

Anastasios Maraslis, president of Marasco Marine, in Cyprus Shipping News on 18 September, asks what owners are actually asking: “If the war premium disappears before I recover my investment, would I still want to own this ship?”

THE SCEPTIC · A PIPELINE REOPENING TO FEED ITS OWN REFINERIES

Rahul Choudhary of Rystad Energy, 17 September, does the sum Friday's rally skipped: the pipeline will restart “at a reduced 40–60 percent capacity... only about 0.5–1 million bpd would be left for export, meaning Yanbu crude exports fall by 2.5–3 million bpd even after a partial restart.”⁵ The price fell because a pipeline half-reopened to keep Saudi refineries lit, not because one extra barrel reached a customer.

On Saturday something looked like an exit: Mohsen Rezaei said Tehran's conditions — a halt to attacks, the release of frozen funds, an end to the blockade — had gone to Washington through Qatar.⁶ Nothing has come back, and prediction markets price a normal Hormuz by month-end at one per cent.² Meanwhile American diesel is at a record US\$6.31 a gallon and Singapore's low-sulphur bunkers are sixty per cent above pre-war.⁴ The war is in the container and the forecourt now (p14).

SOURCES ¹ European term allocations from OilPrice, 18 Sep 2026, and Middle East Monitor, 19 Sep, citing Bloomberg; Orlen's tenders and the June import average from the same MEMO report; Ras Tanura sales, pipeline capacity and restart timing from OilPrice, 18 Sep; Saudi export figures from Al Jazeera, 17 Sep. ² Brent and WTI settlements from the Bloomberg wire via Rigzone, 18 Sep, cross-read against a second quote service; transit counts, dark-tanker screening and the prediction-market line from straits.live, 19 Sep; Sachdeva quoted by Rigzone, 18 Sep. ³ The IRGC Navy statement is quoted as carried by The Hans India and by Siasat/ANS, both 18 Sep; Tasnim's own site returned 503 and is not cited directly. The UKMTO log is quoted via Rio Times, 18 Sep; ukmta.org returned 403. ⁴ Maraslis and the VLCC values from Cyprus Shipping News, 18 Sep; Sand and the container rates from Reuters via Arab News, 18 Sep; the bunker and diesel prices from the same reporting. ⁵ Choudhary quoted in Al Jazeera, 17 Sep. ⁶ Rezaei via the Al Jazeera liveblog, 19 Sep.

AROUND THE DESKS · SUNDAY READING

A government changed hands on fifty thousand votes, a spy agency admitted lying to three courts, and you turned out to have two brains

Three stories from the back half of the week that have nothing to do with oil, and one of them is about the organ that has been worrying about oil.

Sweden finished counting on Thursday. The four-party left bloc has 176 seats; the incumbent right bloc has 173; the Riksdag has 349. Roughly fifty thousand votes separated the two sides in a country of 10.6 million — a margin you could seat in a football ground.¹

The Social Democrats remain the largest single party on 99 seats, down eight. The genuinely new fact sits elsewhere: the Sweden Democrats lost support for the first time, falling from 20.5 per cent to 17.5.¹ Ulf Kristersson resigned by letter to the Speaker.¹

“Social democracy has won the elections in Sweden.” — Pedro Sánchez, 17 September

Fifty thousand votes is not a mandate; it is a coin landing on its edge. Both blocs will now govern as if it were not.

THE ADMISSION

On Friday MI5 accepted that it had given evidence based on lies to **three separate courts**. The subject is “Agent X,” a neo-Nazi informant who used his status to abuse his partner, including an attack with a machete. The investigation, by Sir John Goldring, found “serious and systemic failures in MI5’s conduct”: one senior officer lied repeatedly, another misled his own colleagues.² Counsel for the Service told the High Court that MI5 accepted the findings “without reservation.”

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT AN ADMISSION IS WORTH

“Without reservation” is the cheapest sentence in the English legal language when nobody is named. The test of Friday is not the apology; it is whether the contempt panel identifies a person. Set a reminder rather than a verdict.

AND THE THING DOING THE READING

On Thursday *Nature Neuroscience* published work led from Stanford Medicine arguing that the human brain is not one organ but two, sitting adjacent. The forebrain and the hindbrain arise from *entirely different progenitor cells* — not, as the textbook has it, from a common pool that later specialises.³

Senior author Kyle Loh: “We’ve shown for the first time that the front of the brain arises from a totally different progenitor cell than the back.” Co-first author Rayyan Jokhai supplies the consequence: “Previous attempts to make hindbrain neurons likely tried to coax forebrain and midbrain progenitors into hindbrain cells.”³ The field has spent years asking the wrong cell to become the right one. Growing genuine hindbrain neurons in a dish opens brain-stem disease — spinal muscular atrophy, ALS — to laboratory work.³

THE CHATTER · AND THE REST OF THE WEEK, BRIEFLY

17 Sep. The UN fact-finding mission on Iran, chaired by Sara Hossain, told the Human Rights Council it had found “reasonable grounds to believe the United States committed the war crime of launching indiscriminate attacks”: at least 178 civilians killed in two strikes, 168 of them at an elementary school in Minab, mostly children, per Iranian state media.⁴

18 Sep. South Korea ruled itself out. President Lee Jae Myung: “There will not be a dispatching of troops for involvement or intervention in the war.” Seoul is nonetheless weighing an expanded escort role.⁴

19 Sep. The US president signed the Russia sanctions act authorising tariffs of up to 100 per cent on the five largest buyers of Russian oil and gas.

18 Sep. Washington claimed a Greenland deal giving it “permanent control”; Copenhagen reads the same text as recognising “the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the kingdom.” And the European Commission proposed banning under-thirties from social media outright (p12).⁴

SOURCES ¹ Swedish final count, seat totals, the Sweden Democrats’ share and the Kristersson and Sánchez statements from Al Jazeera, 17 Sep 2026, corroborated on the AP wire, 18 Sep; the Iraq dismissal via Reuters reporting of 13 Sep. ² Goldring findings, the Otty submission and the contempt question from JNS, 18 Sep, and the Just Security Early Edition, 18 Sep; the story was broken by the BBC, whose site would not open for this desk, and is credited accordingly. ³ Loh, Dundes and Jokhai, *Nature Neuroscience*, published 18 Sep 2026; quotations and the clinical framing from Stanford Medicine’s own announcement of the paper. ⁴ UN mission from NBC News, 17 Sep; Lee Jae Myung from the Korea Herald, 18 Sep; the sanctions act and the Greenland statements from Al Jazeera, 19 and 18 Sep; the EU proposal via the Just Security Early Edition, 18 Sep.

SINGAPORE • THE LANTERN WEEKEND

Two numbers, both correct, and only one of them is about tonight

The island's twenty-four-hour index read 108 at six o'clock on Saturday evening. The hourly reading at the same moment was 61. The agency publishes both on purpose, and tells you which one to use.

It did not clear. On Saturday afternoon the central region's twenty-four-hour PSI climbed through 102 at one o'clock, 107 at three, 108 at six and 109 by seven — the top of the island band crossing into Unhealthy.¹

Underneath the running average, the air did something different. The hourly PM2.5 in the same region went 67 at eleven in the morning, **117 at noon**, 93 at three and 61 by six.¹ So at six o'clock the index said 108 and the air said 61.

The National Environment Agency says so itself, in a single line on its own advisory, and it is the most useful line printed in Singapore this week: "Refer to the 1-hr PM2.5 for immediate activities, and the 24-hr PSI forecast to plan ahead."² The average is a planning instrument, not a description of now — and at noon on Saturday it was understating the air badly in the other direction.

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THE CENTRAL REGION'S 24-HOUR PSI AND ITS 1-HOUR PM2.5, BOTH AT 6PM ON SATURDAY. THE FIRST IS FOR TOMORROW; THE SECOND IS FOR THE WALK YOU ARE ABOUT TO TAKE¹

The cause is unchanged and not local: winds from the east-southeast carrying smoke from fires in Kalimantan and southern Sumatra.² Indonesia logged 1,037 high-confidence hotspots on 15 September; the regional centre has held its highest transboundary alert since 27 August, and today's forecast is High Moderate to Mid Unhealthy.³ Which collides with the calendar: Mid-Autumn falls on Friday and the lantern weekend was this one.⁴ All outdoors, under a sky that read 108. Purifiers run in every school and preschool, exams sit in filtered rooms, and N95 masks are not the agency's advice below a 24-hour PSI of 200. Saturday came nowhere near it.⁵

THE CHATTER • THE THIRD STUDIO IN NINE DAYS

Yoga Inc told its instructors by e-mail on Friday night that it had ceased operations with immediate effect; students found out on Saturday morning at Our Tampines Hub. Thirty-two instructors, normally paid on the fifteenth, are unpaid, and the company said only that it "does not have sufficient funds."⁶ On HardwareZone — Reddit was unreachable again — nobody was surprised. **Roadster01**, 5.27am: "With so many abrupt closures with many losing their unused subscriptions, still have many subscribing?" **Yuripa**, Friday 4.47pm: "Sounds so shady behind the scenes."⁶

THE SCEPTIC • A POLICY THAT HAS NOT MOVED IN TEN YEARS

True Fitness and True Yoga shut all ten Singapore outlets on 10 September; within a week CASE had 241 complaints worth more than S\$609,000. Here is the part worth printing. In a forum reply dated **1 August 2016**, still live on its own website, the Ministry of Trade and Industry rejected mandatory prepayment insurance or escrow in favour of education: broad mandates, it argued, would impose "onerous compliance and administrative costs, which may be passed on to consumers."⁷ Ten years and three collapses later the position is unchanged.

IN BRIEF • THE WEEK THE STATE WAS QUIET

Electricity is the next bill. The July–September tariff rose 8.1 per cent to 30.17 cents a kilowatt-hour before GST, about S\$8.25 a month on a four-room flat, and EMA has warned of "further and potentially sharper increases" because Singapore's gas is oil-indexed by contract (**p3**). The fourth-quarter decision is due within days.⁸

Twenty-three rabbits, many with matted fur and overgrown nails, were found abandoned in boxes at a Seletar roadside at about 12.20am on Saturday. **A Muay Thai student** who fought at the National Stadium on 12 September remains in critical condition.⁸

SOURCES 1 Intraday PSI and hourly PM2.5 readings for Saturday 19 Sep 2026 from AsiaOne's running air-quality report, read at source. 2 NEA Haze Situation Update, 19 September 2026, read on nea.gov.sg — the 5pm readings, the wind-direction attribution, the 24-hour forecast and the quoted guidance on which index to use. 3 Hotspot counts from The Online Citizen, 16 Sep, and Bloomberg, 11 Sep; the January–August totals from The Star, 29 Aug; the ASMC alert level from the same reporting. 4 Weekend programming from Time Out Singapore, Little Day Out and The Honeycombers, cross-checked against the organisers' own listings. 5 Mitigation measures and the N95 thresholds from NEA's August 2026 agency statement. 6 Closure details, the instructor count and the customer account from AsiaOne, Mothership and Yahoo, 19 Sep; community quotations read at source on the HardwareZone thread. Reddit was unreachable and nothing is attributed to it. 7 CASE complaint totals from reporting of 17 Sep; the MTI position is quoted from its own forum reply of 1 August 2016, still published on mti.gov.sg; the Pang Chong Liu letter via Singapore Law Watch, 16 Sep. 8 DEPA accession from MTI's joint release, 17 Sep; tariff figures from SP Group's own revision notice and EMA commentary; the Seletar and Muay Thai items from Mothership, 19 Sep.

BUY IT ONCE · HAIRBRUSHES & COMBS

The damage is a mould line, and the comb without one is £4.50

Cut the comb from a sheet instead of moulding it and the ridge cannot exist. The rest of this desk is what the other objects cost.

An ordinary comb is injected into a mould, and a mould has two halves. They meet along the centreline of every tooth and leave a ridge exactly where hair slides — in Mason Pearson's own distributor's words, "an area of increased friction on each tooth where the two parts of the mold join."¹

The fix is a different process: cut the comb from solid sheet, so no parting line can exist. Kent's combs are "made from large sheets of Cellulose Acetate rather than being moulded."² The saw kills the seam; the hand-polish rounds the tip. Kent charges £4.50.

Now the brush. **Boar bristle is keratin, and so is your hair. Nylon is not.** A bristle is a hair, so it wets, picks up sebum and carries it down; a nylon quill is extruded monofilament, incapable of holding oil. What it does is grip.³ And read Mason Pearson's sizing guide correctly: pure bristle for fine hair, bristle-and-nylon for normal to thick, nylon for thick. **A stiffness ladder, not a quality ladder** — the pure-boar grail is the maker's answer for the weakest hair.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHO ACTUALLY MAKES YOUR FAMOUS ENGLISH COMB

Mason Pearson is careful with its noun: "All our brushes are manufactured in-house at our factory in the UK." The comb page says something else: "Our combs are handcrafted in Switzerland... smoothly tapered teeth and rounded tips."⁴

Now read Baxter of California: "Handcrafted in Switzerland... smoothly tapered teeth and rounded tips." Word for word — at US\$30.⁵

Denman publishes the trade openly: a D3 at £12 and a "Jack Dean D3" at £12, one object and two badges — and its branding page gives the terms: "Standard MOQ is 240pcs."⁶

The one number that prices craft cleanly. Kostkamm, making since 1848, publishes both halves of a comparison nobody else does: the same brush at €59 machine-set and

€242 hand-drawn. **Four point one times, for the tufting method alone.**⁷ Kent's hand-drawn satinwood is £235; the Mason Pearson Popular £154, or US\$325 in America.⁴

Singapore reverses this one. Mason Pearson lists no stockist here, will not post here, and refuses UK freight forwarders while disowning marketplace sellers it cannot verify — so every local listing is, by the maker's own definition, outside its distribution agreement.⁴ Kent ships worldwide, **free over £30.**² And skip the horn: Abbeyhorn's care page forbids this climate — "avoid sudden or extreme changes in temperature and humidity."⁸

THE SCEPTIC · ONE TRIAL EXISTS, AND IT POINTS THE OTHER WAY

The claim the category rests on carries no citation. A 2024 dermatology review says boar bristle "distributes natural scalp oils... closes hair strand cuticles, and increases blood flow to the scalp" — and references none of it, while carefully referencing the harms.⁹

The only controlled trial on brushing found the opposite of the ritual: "hair loss was reduced by reducing brushing frequency." Fourteen women, four weeks — small, imperfect, and the only experiment there is.⁹

And the dupe economy rests on comparisons nobody performed: the most-linked Mason Pearson dupe review discloses, in the same post, "I have never touched or used the Mason Pearson."¹⁰ The anti-static pitch fails here too: humidity reduces triboelectric charging, so at eighty-two per cent the problem is frizz — swelling, not charge.⁸

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Coffee grinders — burr alignment and particle distribution, in a landscape that shames pepper mills.

Enamelware & camp mugs — glass fused to steel, and why the chip is the whole argument.

Tea ware — Yixing zisha and tetsubin: where the clay changes the cup, and where it is theatre.

SOURCES 1 The moulding seam and the Swiss saw-cut sequence, read at source on Mason Pearson's US distributor Tressence and on a US stockist's process description, 19 September 2026. 2 Kent Brushes' own product data and delivery pages, read 19 September 2026 — comb material and method, all comb and brush prices, and the Rest-of-World shipping terms. 3 Bristle grading, the "100% boar" labelling loophole and the first-cut follicle test from the German brushmaker Leo Prinz (Julian Dietrich, 15 February 2021) and from a bristle house's own grade list. 4 Mason Pearson's own site — sizing guide, craft page, comb page, brand-protection page, global stockist list and live prices. The site blocks this build behind a captcha, so every figure and quote is taken from Internet Archive captures dated between February 2024 and April 2026, and is labelled as such. 5 Baxter of California product copy and prices, read live 19 September 2026; the third Swiss-sourced label is Corpus Naturals, read the same day. 6 Denman's own product catalogue and custom-branding page, read live 19 September 2026. 7 Kostkamm's own catalogue and craft page, read live 19 September 2026; euro and sterling converted at mid-market rates of 18 September. 8 Abbeyhorn's product-care and sourcing pages, read 19 September 2026; the humidity-and-charge relation from a standard reference on the triboelectric effect. 9 Williams, Lee, Robles and Tosti, *Skin Appendage Disorders*, 2024, read at source; and Kiderman, Gur and Ever-Hadani, *Journal of Dermatological Treatment*, 2009, abstract read at source. 10 The dupe review is dated 8 July 2024 and read at source. Reddit was unreachable on every path again this session, and Styleforum and one menswear forum returned 403 and 402; nothing on this page is attributed to any of them.

TECHNOLOGY · THE AGENT IN YOUR REPOSITORY

Seven hundred megabytes, and you hold none of the keys

A developer noticed a cache folder had grown past 700MB. It turned out to be his entire git history, encrypted with a public key served fresh by the vendor, uploaded before every prompt — and the private key never leaves the cloud.

The tell was disk space. On Thursday a developer looked at `~/zcode`, found it past seven hundred megabytes, and started pulling it apart.¹

ZCode is Zhipu's coding agent. What it had been doing, on this machine, was packaging the entire workspace — including the whole of `.git`: commit history, reflogs, LFS caches, config — encrypting it and shipping it out.

The cryptography is the part worth reading twice. Content goes under AES-256-CTR; the symmetric key is wrapped with RSA-OAEP. In the author's words: *"the RSA public key used for encryption is delivered on the fly by the server, while the private key lives exclusively in the cloud."*¹ So the ciphertext sitting on your own disk, made from your own source, cannot be opened by you.

~90%

SHARE OF THE CAPTURED SNAPSHOT VOLUME THAT WAS
.GIT — NOT THE CODE YOU WERE EDITING, THE RECORD OF
EVERYTHING YOU HAVE EVER EDITED¹

It fired "before every prompt" and during repository indexing, and the two toggles that look as though they would stop it do not, while you are signed in: "No UI setting can turn it off." Three of those four claims are unverifiable from outside, which is the entire point of the story.

THE CHATTER · THE MITIGATION IS ONE LINE, AND IT IS A PADLOCK

The author's own fix, before any patch existed, is to make the directory immutable at the filesystem level — `chflags uchg` on macOS, `chattr +i` on Linux.¹ an agent with your repository open has, by construction, everything: the code you deleted, the key you committed by mistake in 2021 and rotated. **You cannot redact a git history after the fact.**

THE SCEPTIC · MARTIN FOWLER, WHO USES THEM ANYWAY

On Wednesday Martin Fowler published a piece called, flatly, "I Don't Like LLMs".²

"I don't like them," he writes. "They talk to me in this grating LLM-voice, an uncanny valley of talking to a real human." And: "They confidently bullshit me — often giving me useful, helpful answers. But also just making stuff up with the same assurance."

And then: "not only are they useful, it is irresponsible not to use them.... They're more thorough, as well as faster."²

SOVEREIGNTY, THE HARD NEWS

GLM-5.3-Flash now runs production inference on more than 100,000 Chinese-made accelerators — 320 billion parameters, 18 billion active, a million-token window, served entirely off domestic silicon. Tested anonymously, it took 62 trillion tokens in six days.³ Set that against No. 105's US\$5.6bn Blackwell loophole: it matters less each month the domestic stack works.

Also this week: Qwen3.8-Omni-Flash landed Friday — native text, image, audio and video, a million-token context, audio input 98 per cent cheaper per hour, and the weights not open. And Crusoe raised US\$3.9bn at a US\$30.9bn valuation with **GIC on the investor list**.³

"The largest theft of labor in human history." — Brent Hecht, Microsoft's Director of Applied Science, in an internal memo of January 2023, unredacted this week

That line is from newly unsealed filings in the *New York Times* case, and the numbers around it are the ones to keep: Copilot drove click-through to *nytimes.com* down by as much as **93 per cent** against traditional Bing, and one crawl held over two million Times documents.⁴

SOURCES 1 Discovery, the encryption scheme, the archive sizes, the upload trigger, the quoted UI finding and the vendor's 18 September response are from the developer's own write-up at blog.ferstar.org, read at source, with the two Hacker News discussions (items 49750694 and 49752422) read for the community line. 2 Martin Fowler, "I Don't Like LLMs", martinfowler.com, 17 Sep 2026, quoted from the article itself. 3 GLM-5.3-Flash infrastructure figures from Z.ai's own engineering post, whose page body is script-rendered and was read via unite.ai's transcription; Qwen3.8-Omni-Flash from Qwen's own launch post, 18 Sep; India Semiconductor Mission 2.0 from Business Today's SEMICON India report, 17 Sep; Crusoe's round, investor list and capacity figures from its own newsroom release, 17 Sep. 4 Hecht memo, the Nadella deposition and the corpus counts from TechCrunch's report on the unredacted filings, 17 Sep 2026.

THE HOME LAB · A 27B MODEL IN 5.95 GIGABYTES

Ninety-eight per cent of the capability, and a quarter of the agentic coding

The headline retention figure is a mean across twenty benchmarks. Two of those twenty fell off a cliff, and they are the two you would actually use it for.

On Thursday PrismML released Ternary Bonsai 2 27B under Apache 2.0: Alibaba's Qwen3.8 27B, re-expressed in ternary weights at 1.76 effective bits apiece. Fifty-four gigabytes at full precision becomes **5.95**.¹

The vendor's own table: 129–143 tokens a second on a 5090, 91–97 on a 4090, about 47 on an M5 Max.¹

The headline is 98.2 per cent retention: an aggregate of 83.9 against the full-precision model's 85.4. Underneath it, on PrismML's own table: **SWE-bench Verified 60.8 against 80.6. Terminal-Bench 52.8 against 69.7**.² The mean is honest and the mean is useless.

60.8 vs 80.6

SWE-BENCH VERIFIED, COMPRESSED AGAINST FULL PRECISION — ONE OF TWENTY NUMBERS THAT PRODUCED "98.2 PER CENT RETENTION"²

And there is a second catch: you cannot run it. The file uses two new tensor types that mainline llama.cpp has not merged, so stock tooling "rejects them as unknown types" and the feature request is still open.³ You build the vendor's fork or you do not run the model.

THE CHATTER · THE FIRST INDEPENDENT NUMBERS WERE AMATEURS, OVERNIGHT

With no reviewer having reproduced anything, the Hacker News thread — 575 points — became the benchmark. **simonw**, 17 Sep 22:13 UTC, posted a working recipe and got about twenty tokens a second on an M5 Pro with Metal acceleration off; forty minutes later, "It took 18 minutes 20 seconds. Pretty decent for a 5.5GB model file."⁴

jakswa: 89 tokens a second on an RX 7900 XTX. And the floor, from **Dwedit**: "It needs more VRAM than just the model weights. With 6GB of VRAM, I got 44/65 layers loaded into VRAM" — 0.67 tokens a second.⁴ The file fits in six gigabytes. The workload does not.

THE SCEPTIC · "NEAR LOSSLESS", TESTED BY HAND

redox99, 18 Sep 01:54 UTC: "I tried their WebGPU version and it immediately started looping. Yeah 'near lossless' my ass. Plus the reasoning that it looped on was clearly wrong and unlike the non quantized 27B."⁴ **Aurornis**, later the same day: "I don't know how they get such good results on these benchmarks because using them gives a very different experience... I don't think they're useful as coding agents."⁴ Which is exactly what the two collapsed benchmarks predict. One independent write-up states it plainly: "Every figure in this list is Prism MLs; none of it is independently verified."²

SINGAPORE PRICES, 12 SEPTEMBER — AND THE BUY-ONCE ARGUMENT

Every single RTX 5090 SKU on it is pinned at exactly S\$8,999 — eight boards from four vendors, to the dollar.

AT ONE COUNTER, 12 SEP	MEMORY	S\$
DGX Spark, 4TB	128 GB unified	8,299
RTX 5090 (any SKU)	32 GB GDDR7	8,999
Intel Arc Pro B60 blower	24 GB	1,195
RTX PRO 6000 Blackwell	96 GB	28,999

Read the first two rows together. A box with 128GB of unified memory and four terabytes of storage costs **seven hundred dollars less** than a 32GB graphics card on the same shelf. The US street price, meanwhile, is unquotable: one tracker had the 5090 at US\$6,449 on the fourteenth, another logged US\$4,599.99 in stock on the eighteenth.⁵ Treat any 5090 price as a twenty-four-hour number.

SOURCES 1 Release date, licence, bit-width, file sizes, throughput table and the energy figure from PrismML's own announcement and the Hugging Face model card, both read at source, 19 Sep 2026. 2 Per-benchmark scores from PrismML's published comparison table as reproduced and checked by orcarouter.ai, 18 Sep, which also carries the two quoted verification caveats; the medium-effort retention figure from modemguides.com, 17 Sep. 3 llama.cpp issue 29058, opened 18 Sep 2026, read at source with its comment thread; the release feed was checked to build b11056 (19 Sep, 17:52 UTC) for any merged support. 4 Hacker News item 49746618, all quoted comments read at source with their posting timestamps. 5 Singapore prices read off the Bizgram Asia PDF price list dated 12 Sep 2026, published via HardwareZone, 16 Sep; the two conflicting US street prices from ai.rs, 14 Sep, and videocardprices.com, 18 Sep, both read at source and both printed because they disagree.

THE KIT · THE POCKET THAT DOES NOT BUZZ

The price everyone printed is the Hong Kong price

Onyx's new pocket E Ink Android takes a pen, wears aluminium and costs US\$339.99. Every review this week said US\$319.99 — which is the figure on the Asia listing, twenty dollars below the American one.

A six-inch monochrome screen, Google Play, no notifications you did not ask for, and 195 grams. Onyx's own line is "Quiet by design... Built for analog living," which is marketing and also accurate.¹

New over the Palma 2: Android 16 in place of 13; an anodised aluminium frame where there was plastic; a fingerprint reader in the power button; and **active stylus support**, which the black-and-white Palma has never had. The panel is unchanged at 300 pixels per inch, as are the memory, storage and battery. It is 25 grams heavier.¹

Now the price, because this is the part nobody has got right. Read off Onyx's own structured product data on Friday, the store carries two listings: "**BOOX Palma 3 – US**" at **US\$339.99** and "**BOOX Palma 3 – Hong Kong**" at **US\$319.99**.¹ Every write-up this week quoted the lower figure. It is the Asia-region SKU. The stylus is a separate US\$45.99.

+21%

PALMA 3 AT US\$339.99 AGAINST THE PALMA 2'S US\$279.99 LAUNCH — A SIXTY-DOLLAR STEP IN THE YEAR MEMORY BECAME THE REASON EVERYTHING COSTS MORE (PB)²

Singapore has no listing at all yet: the official store carried sixteen SKUs on Friday and no Palma 3.¹ The Palma 2 landed here at S\$435 against a US\$279.99 list — a multiplier of about 1.55, which would put the Palma 3 near **S\$525**. That is our arithmetic, not a quoted price. One spec is unresolved: two outlets say the panel is E Ink Carta 1300, two say 1200, and Onyx's own page declines to name a generation.² When a maker will not print a number, it is not a selling point.

THE CHATTER · ON THE MAKER'S OWN COMMENT THREAD

Reddit was unreachable, and Hacker News barely registered this — one point, one comment. So the community read is the specialist press's own comment section, all posted on Thursday.

RNG, 10:51am: "I have to wonder what the market for these looks like — these are too expensive to be annual purchases, but I can't imagine there are *that* many people wanting to spend \$300+ on Palmas."³

Mary, 1:49pm, who owned the original: "What I don't like about Boox is having to fiddle around with it... there were default apps on the home screen I never could figure out."³ That is the honest cost of Android on an e-reader, and it is on no spec sheet.

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS HELD ONE

Nathan Groezinger, who reviewed and rated the Palma 2, on Thursday: "The main thing I didn't like about it was the high price, and unfortunately, the Palma 3 is even more expensive... Considering the Palma 2 sold for \$279, that's a pretty big jump." He names the cheap alternative: a PocketBook pocket reader, no Android, expected at US\$199.³

And the measured verdict does not exist. We checked RTINGS, Notebookcheck and the specialist e-ink press on Friday: no independent test, because the device has not shipped.² Its verdict on the upgrade is the one to hold: *readers gain little; note-takers have the strongest reason.*

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sonos Ace Ultra — US\$449 / S\$699, general availability 29 September. Checked again on Friday: ten days out and nobody outside Sonos has put a microphone on it, so it stays where No. 106 left it.⁴

Canon EOS R8 Mark II — US\$1,899 body, S\$2,519 here. Pre-orders are open; it ships in late October, so nobody has a shipping body.⁴

Meta Connect runs 23–24 September; the keynote is 7am Singapore time on Thursday, and a new pair of glasses has been teased with the identifying features scratched out. A fourth-generation headset is not expected — that has moved to 2027.⁴

E INK

ANDROID 16

UNREVIEWED

NO SG LISTING

SOURCES 1 Specification, marketing copy, the two regional listings and their prices read off Onyx's own product page and its embedded structured product data, 19 September 2026; the stylus price from the same store; the Singapore catalogue read on the official regional store the same day, where the Palma 3 does not appear. The S\$525 figure is this desk's arithmetic from the Palma 2's own US-to-Singapore multiplier and is not quoted by anyone. 2 Palma 2 launch price via TechSpot; the generation comparison and the "independent testing still needs to establish" line from TechRepublic, 17 September 2026; the Carta 1200-versus-1300 conflict is between two pairs of outlets, with Onyx declining to name a generation. 3 Nathan Groezinger's review piece and the named reader comments beneath it, The eBook Reader, 17 September 2026, read at source. Reddit was unreachable this session. 4 Sonos availability re-checked against RTINGS and What Hi-Fi, 19 September; Canon pricing and ship window from Canon's own 15 September release; Meta Connect timings from the event's own page.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE WATCH YOU CANNOT BUY

It is called Perpetual and it is not a perpetual calendar

Two hundred hours of patent work to make an annual calendar from two extra components, a moon cut from meteorite — and no product page, no Singapore price, and a reviewer who says out loud who gets one.

Thirty-nine millimetres across and 12.20 thick; day, date, month and moon; Calibre 7190, on the architecture that arrived with the Land-Dweller — silicon Dynapulse escapement, Syloxi hairspring, sixty-six hours, minus two to plus two seconds a day.¹

The engineering to read twice is the calendar. Where a conventional annual calendar carries a small mechanical computer, this carries a cam on the back of a part that was already there.

And then the name. It is a Perpetual Padellone and it is **not a perpetual calendar**: it needs correcting once a year, on the first of March. Tom Pettit at *Oracle of Time* handles it correctly — “a complete calendar... with an annual mechanism behind it” — and defends it: “Personally, I think that is the better watch.” “Perpetual” here is the collection, not the complication.²

REFERENCE	US\$	CHF
18ct Everose, white dial, alligator	59,000	52,500
Everose on the Settimo bracelet	72,800	64,800
950 platinum, ice-blue dial	66,200	59,000

No Singapore price is published anywhere this desk could reach. Rolex's own site and newsroom both refused us; the official Singapore retailer lists none. Boutique allocation only.¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE QUIET PART, IN A REVIEW

Johnny Brayson of *Gear Patrol*, on launch day, writes the sentence most of the trade declines to: “The Perpetual Padellone does not yet have a true product page on Rolex's website, though it should hypothetically be available now to very well-connected individuals, e.g., Roger Federer and Leonardo DiCaprio.”³

Mike Espindle at *Watchonista* supplies the pattern: “when the 1908 came out three years ago, the upload was slow, very slow. Expect the same here.”³ A launch price on a watch with no product page is a number, not an offer.

THE CHATTER · THE ENTHUSIASTS ARE NOT CHARMED

“**Zahn**”, 08:53: “Rolex's ‘Not For Sale’ catalog just added a new item.”

And the one that carries forward from No. 105, “**Abner**”, 12:32: “I'm a bit mystified why high-end brands still offer their best bracelets without micro-adjustment.”⁴

ALSO ON THE BENCH THIS WEEK

Schiit has abandoned multibit. The Bifrost 3 drops the True Multibit architecture the company built its identity on for “Mesh” — a single ESS part run as a delta-sigma modulator behind Schiit's own oversampling filter.⁵

This is the measurement-versus-multibit argument of the last decade resolved by the company that started it, in favour of the measurers. We have no community read: the relevant forum served a security challenge instead of the page. **Nobody has measured it.** It ships, in Schiit's own scheduling language, “Halloween 2026.”⁵

-US\$100

BIFROST 3 AGAINST THE BIFROST 2 IT REPLACES — WITH THE REMOTE AND THE FORKBEARD MODULE NOW IN THE BOX⁵

ANNUAL, NOT PERPETUAL

NO SG PRICE

UNMEASURED

SOURCES 1 Dimensions, calibre, escapement, power reserve, the Haplos description and all three prices from aBlogtoWatch and Monochrome, both 15 September 2026, and SJX, 16 September, read at source and cross-checked; where the three disagree on balance frequency we print the figure two of them give and that matches the calibre's lineage. Rolex's own site and newsroom returned 403 to this desk; the official Singapore retailer publishes no price. 2 Tom Pettit, *Oracle of Time*, 16 September 2026. 3 Johnny Brayson, *Gear Patrol*, and Mike Espindle, *Watchonista*, both 15 September 2026. 4 Reader comments on Monochrome's review, 16 September 2026, read at source with their timestamps. Reddit, Hodinkee and Head-Fi all refused this desk. 5 Architecture, pricing, published measurements, warranty and ship window from Schiit's own product page and its 9 September announcement, with coverage in Hifi Pig, 14 September. No independent measurement of the Bifrost 3 exists at the time of writing.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE GAP INVERTS

Ninety-five from the critics, ninety-one from the crowd — and a record nobody expected a video game to hold

Two weeks ago this desk had a film at thirty-five per cent from critics and ninety-two from the audience. This week the numbers changed sides, and the film that did it opened in Singapore a day before America saw it.

Thursday previews took US\$8.8 million, the biggest in the franchise's history. Friday took **US\$26.3 million** from 3,684 theatres. Sony is calling US\$53–55 million for the weekend.¹

The numbers that matter to this desk are the other ones. Read on Friday: **95 per cent from 187 critics** on the Tomatometer, against **91 per cent** from the audience; a Metascore of **81 from 44 reviews**, against a user score of 7.8.² Two issues ago this desk printed thirty-five and ninety-two the other way round. The aggregate flipped sides, and both times the single number concealed the disagreement that was the story.

The claim being made for it — the first film from a video-game property to take Metacritic's "Universal Acclaim" seal — is a threshold artefact, not a verdict. The board under it is not flat: Rolling Stone 100, the Hollywood Reporter 90, IndieWire 83, the Guardian 80, and *Empire* 60.²

17 Sep

SINGAPORE'S OPENING DATE — A DAY BEFORE THE US WIDE RELEASE. GOLDEN VILLAGE, SHAW AND EAGLE WINGS, IN STANDARD DIGITAL, IMAX, LUMIÈRE AND GOLD CLASS³

THE SCEPTIC · THE ENTHUSIASM AND THE NUMBER DO NOT MATCH

Empire's **Harry Stainer** supplies the week's cleanest example of a review reading warmer than it scores: "Horror fans will happily gobble up this tight, bloody, 90-minute thrill-ride" — filed at 60.² That mismatch is what an average of forty-four such judgements smooths away.

The substantive dissent is about the ending. **Jesse Hassenger** in the Guardian, at four stars: "After doing a great job making us care about Bryan for more than 90 minutes, Cregger seems to abandon him a few steps shy of completing any real journey." And **Jeffrey Lyles** gets the sharpest line of the week: "Resident Evil would be a vastly superior film with basically any other title."²

THE CHATTER · WHAT PEOPLE ACTUALLY SAID, IN FOUR STARS

Reddit was unreachable, and Hacker News has no thread on the film at all. So: Letterboxd, read Friday, where the reviews arrive without dates but with an unusual amount of accuracy.

James (Schaffrillas), four and a half: "Unsurprisingly Cregger knew what he was doing. A rip-roaring nightmare that perfectly emulates the look and feel of the games." **alklku**, four, in one line: "the backstory of that one random dead npc you find in every resident evil game." **starstruck**, four: "a cautionary tale about the dangers of having a job."³

AND THE RECORD THAT IS QUIETLY THE BETTER STORY

Beck released *Ride Lonesome* on Friday — twelve tracks, forty-seven minutes, mixed by Nigel Godrich. It is **seven years** since *Hyperspace*, the longest gap of his career, and he has reassembled the *Sea Change* and *Morning Phase* personnel to close it.⁴

Metacritic has it at 87 from fourteen reviews. The Guardian's Alexis Petridis gives five stars and a "stunning end to the heartache trilogy"; MOJO five, "a masterpiece of melancholia"; Rolling Stone four. The dissent is Slant, at three and a half, under a headline that does the work: "**Same Old Road, Some Nice Views**."⁴ And the detail for this desk: released with the album is a video for "Run Away", **shot in Tokyo and starring Tadanobu Asano**.

Still running: *Practical Magic 2*, covered here at a 35-per-cent Tomatometer and a 92-per-cent audience score, took another US\$3.30 million on Friday for a cume of US\$41.2 million on day eight. The crowd was right and has stayed right.¹

An open envelope: Toronto announces its People's Choice Award today, after this edition went to press. The front-runners are *Wild Horse Nine*, *The Debut* and *I Play Rocky*. We will print the result, not a prediction.³

SOURCES 1 Preview and Friday grosses, theatre count and the continuing *Practical Magic 2* figures from the Box Office Mojo daily chart for 18 September 2026, read 19 September; the weekend projection and budget from trade reporting whose full articles are paywalled to this desk and are cited for the headline figures only. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic scores read at source on 19 September 2026 and printed with that read date; individual critic scores and the quoted lines from the Metacritic board and from the Guardian and RogerEbert.com reviews themselves. 3 Singapore release date, distributor and cinema list from Popcorn SG, read at source; the IMDA classification could not be verified and is omitted. Letterboxd reviews read at source, 19 September; the site does not surface per-review dates on a film page. Festival items from awards trade coverage. 4 Track count, running time, personnel and singles chronology from the label's own release material, 18 September 2026; review scores from Metacritic and Any Decent Music; the Tokyo video's director and star and the tour dates from the label's own announcement.

THE FAMILY DESK · FIFTY PER CENT OF WHAT, EXACTLY

A press release said “fifty per cent more effective.” For most children the trial found nothing at all

A 1,793-child randomised trial across forty-four German schools, mean age thirteen point one, tested therapy against media literacy. The headline belongs to 205 children. The other 1,588 are the story.

Forty-four secondary schools in Baden-Württemberg; 1,793 pupils, mean age 13.1, randomised *within* ninety classes; four ninety-minute sessions in school hours; follow-up at one, four and twelve months; intention-to-treat.¹

One arm got cognitive behavioural therapy; the other a *structurally identical* media-literacy programme.

Now the results. Across the whole sample at twelve months, $d = -0.07$, interval -0.16 to 0.01 : not significant, and nothing significant on any secondary outcome. In the high-risk subsample — the 205 children, eleven per cent of the cohort, already meeting two or more diagnostic criteria at baseline — therapy ran 14.7 against 17.7: $d = -0.30$, interval -0.55 to -0.05 , small to moderate and barely clear of zero.¹

205 of 1,793

THE CHILDREN THE EFFECT WAS FOUND IN. FOR THE OTHER 1,588 THE SCHOOL PROGRAMME — EITHER KIND — CHANGED ESSENTIALLY NOTHING¹

The authors say so: “These findings support the use of CBT-based approaches primarily *within indicated*, rather than universal, prevention.”¹ The university’s announcement translated that into: “the behavioral therapy program is **50 percent more effective...** than the media education program.”² Fifty per cent is a ratio of two within-group effect sizes inside a subgroup of 205.

THE SCEPTIC · AND ONE INSTRUMENT OUT OF FOUR

And the one that should be quoted whenever this trial is cited: “**intervention effects were evident only on the modified CSAS, whereas the other scales... showed no significant group differences.**”¹ Four measuring instruments. One moved.

THE CHATTER · THE SECOND PAPER, AND THE BAN SINGAPORE IS WATCHING

A companion finding landed on 1 September at *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology*: 960 secondary pupils tracked across **eight waves** through one academic year — one before a total school smartphone ban and seven after. “No short-term changes emerged in social loneliness, friend support, or cyberbullying victimization.”

The conclusion is the part for the ministry file: “smartphone bans alone are unlikely to improve adolescents’ social well-being; effective school policies should combine such restrictions with broader initiatives that foster social connection.”³

WHERE SINGAPORE IS GOING, AND WHEN

Mandatory daily time limits are being “**seriously discussed**” for under-eighteens, the Minister for Digital Development and Information said in August: a cap introduces a natural stopping point that platform design deliberately removes. The enforcement lever is unusual — if a platform will not implement the stronger safeguards, Singapore intends to *raise its minimum age of access to eighteen*. Legislation is due early in 2027.⁴

Nine months into the Australian experiment, the regulator’s figures: more than eight in ten under-sixteens still use social media, and among those still holding accounts on restricted platforms, **seventy per cent said getting round it had been “easy.”**⁵

SOURCES 1 Lindenbergh, Kewitz, Neumann, Brand, Huth, Lardinois, Leo, Szász-Janocha, King and Wartberg, “Cognitive Behavioral Therapy vs Media Literacy for Prevention of Gaming Disorder and Unspecified Internet Use Disorder: A Randomized Clinical Trial”, *JAMA Network Open*, 4 September 2026 (registration DRKS00033989). Design, sample, ages, both effect sizes with their confidence intervals, the conclusion and the quoted limitations read in the full text. 2 Heidelberg University’s own announcement of the trial, 4 September 2026, quoting the lead author. 3 Vereecke, Vanherle, Nassen, Boen, Eggermont, Beullens, Vandenbosch and Schreurs, “More Than Disconnecting? School Smartphone Bans and Adolescents’ Social Well-being”, *Frontiers in Developmental Psychology*, accepted 1 September 2026; quotations from the published abstract, the only part yet posted. 4 The minister’s remarks were made in a media interview on 28 August 2026 and reported 31 August–1 September; read here via regional carriers, as the Singapore original is behind a paywall this desk cannot open. 5 Australian usage figures from the eSafety Commissioner’s own data as reported by the BMJ group and Al Jazeera, August 2026.

THE TWEEN YEARS • THE LEVER, AND HOW THE STUDY REACHED YOU

Sleep explains thirty-six per cent of it. Screens explain five

A mediation analysis in exactly the right age band, and a cautionary tale about a study your feed served you on Tuesday that was published in April.

The most useful number for a parent of a twelve-year-old this month comes from a mediation analysis on the ABCD cohort, age band **ten to thirteen**, in *Psychological Medicine*.¹

Asked what carries the association between a child's mental-health symptoms and their school grades, it finds: **sleep accounts for 36.3 per cent** of the anxiety-to-grades pathway and 18.5 per cent of the depression pathway. **Screen time is a distant second at five to 6.3 per cent.**¹

The senior author puts it plainly: "Sleep is something parents and families can address... healthy sleep routines are a practical way to support a child's emotional well-being."¹ That is No. 105's sceptic — who argued the screen effect runs *through* sleep — re-run in the band that contains a Secondary One pupil, and it vindicates the quietest thing the Ministry did this year: moving the school device sleep window to **half past ten**.²

36.3% vs 5%

SHARE OF THE ANXIETY-TO-GRADES ASSOCIATION CARRIED BY SLEEP, AGAINST SCREEN TIME, IN TEN-TO-THIRTEEN-YEAR-OLDS. IF YOU CAN MOVE ONE THING, MOVE BEDTIME¹

HOW A STUDY REACHES YOU

On 15 September a wave of coverage ran under headlines of the form "More time on social media means more anxiety, depression for teens," reporting that one extra hour of daily use was linked to a **fifteen per cent higher chance of moderate to severe depression**.³

First, it is not new. The paper, on Canadian adolescents aged twelve to eighteen, was published online on **7 April 2026**.³ What happened on Tuesday was a press cycle, not a finding.

Second, the paper does not report that number. Its method is multilevel *linear* modelling on symptom scales; the "fifteen per cent higher chance" is a coefficient re-expressed into a form that reads like a

risk.³ And gender moderated the association in the cross-sectional waves — girls worst affected — but **not** in the longitudinal one, the wave that carries any causal weight.

THE SCEPTIC • "DON'T BE ALARMIST", FROM PEOPLE WHO STUDY THIS FOR A LIVING

The strongest counterweight to the month's coverage is a Science Media Centre round-up, and the names matter as much as the lines.

Prof Amy Orben, MRC Cognition and Brain Sciences Unit, Cambridge: "What we currently lack is strong scientific evidence on whether banning social media for certain ages is an effective way."

Prof Sarah-Jayne Blakemore, Chair of Psychology at Cambridge, on the UK's announced ban: "We must make the online world safer for children and young people, but a social media ban alone might not achieve that."⁴

None of them says screens are harmless. All say the *ban* is the part without evidence — precisely the part every government is now legislating.

THE CHATTER • THE STUDY YOU WILL BE SENT NEXT

Warning labels. A Stanford, UNC and UC Davis randomised experiment, n=1,012: mental-health-harm warnings rated most effective. The lead author is careful — "Our data suggest these warnings *could* work." It measured **perceived** effectiveness.⁵

Eating disorders and class. A UCL and Copenhagen review, 51 studies, 26,174 adolescents: teenagers whose parents did not attend university were roughly 25 per cent more likely to report symptoms.⁵

THE PRACTICAL PAGE, FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD IN SECONDARY ONE

Move bedtime, not the phone. Thirty-six per cent against five is not a close call.

Know whether your child is in the eleven per cent (p12).

The trial that worked, worked on children already in difficulty; for everyone else the school assembly changed nothing measurable. And read the date on the study: the one your feed served you on Tuesday was five months old, and its headline number was a translation, not a result.

GENERAL GUIDANCE

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

SOURCES 1 UC Davis Health analysis of the ABCD cohort, *Psychological Medicine*, announced 4 August 2026; mediation percentages and the senior author's quotation from the university's own release. Age band 10–13. 2 The device-management sleep window change is Ministry of Education policy reported in November 2025 and in force from January 2026. 3 Curle, Hunter, Leatherdale, Patte, Faulkner, Goldfield, Ferro, Turcotte-Tremblay and Carson, *Journal of Adolescence*, 2026;98(4):1396–1408, published online 7 April 2026 — read via the NCBI record because the publisher refused this desk; sample sizes, age range and the stated modelling approach are from that record. The 15 September coverage is cited as coverage. 4 Science Media Centre expert round-up, 16 January 2026, and the University of Cambridge expert reaction, 15 June 2026, both read at source; titles and affiliations as each gives them. 5 The warning-label experiment, *JAMA Health Forum*, 4 September 2026, and the UCL–Copenhagen systematic review, *International Journal of Eating Disorders*, September 2026, both via their institutions' announcements.

THE MACRO DESK · THE WEEK THE AVERAGE SAID NOTHING

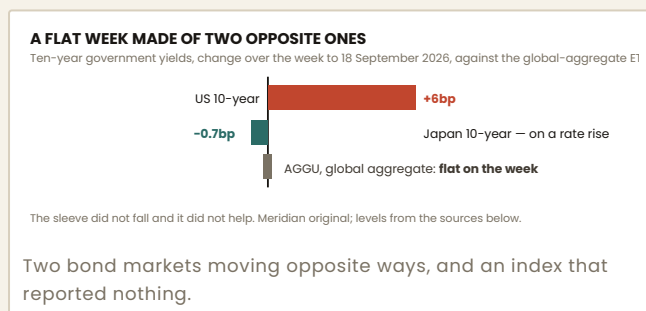
Global bonds finished flat, and that flat number hid two opposite weeks

Treasuries sold off, JGBs rallied on a Bank of Japan hike, and the global-aggregate wrapper netted to zero — no cushion and no second wound. Meanwhile the Fed deleted the word the market used as a stopping rule.

Twenty-five basis points was not the event. On Wednesday the Federal Reserve raised to 3.75–4.00 per cent, twelve votes to none, and the damage was done in the press conference.¹

Asked whether he thinks in terms of a neutral rate, the chair answered: “**In a word, no....** Do I think it has any operational effect on decisions that we make today? No, I don’t.” And the framing that replaced it: “We removed a dose of accommodation, so that financial and credit conditions would be more consistent with our ultimate objectives.”¹

Delete neutral and you delete the market’s stopping rule. **Krishna Guha** of Evercore ISI put it cleanly: taken literally, it “raises the possibility that rates might have to keep going up until financial conditions... are no longer ‘accommodative’” — “a relatively open-ended prospect.”²



Tokyo is why the picture looks like that. On Friday the Bank of Japan raised to around 1.25 per cent by seven votes to two — its *highest rate since April 1995*.

The reaction inverted the textbook: Japan raised rates and the yen **fell** past 157, JGB yields **fell** for a third session, the Nikkei rose.³

AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE, 18 SEP	LEVEL	WEEK
VWRA (All-World)	\$191.66	▼ -1.03%
AGGU (global agg)	\$5.76	flat
US 10-year	4.997%	▲ +6bp

US 2s10s spread	0.24%	▼ from 0.74%
DX	100.22	▲ +1.1%
USD/JPY	156.87	▲ +1.2%
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,383.45	▲ +0.97% Fri
Brent (Nov)	\$103.87	▼ -0.91% Fri
STI	5,656.11	▼ -0.08%

Corrections to our own record, made rather than buried. No. 106 printed the STI at 5,660.52 as Friday’s close: that was **Thursday’s**. It printed the US ten-year at 4.951 per cent, down five basis points; the settlement was **4.997, up six**, after touching 5.04. VWRA has a fresh close and the held print is released; AGGU is verified and no longer omitted. Gold, at US\$4,383, is **21.8 per cent below** its January record.⁴

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

The regime is higher-for-longer, dollar-bid and tightening — and it is not risk-off. The curve flattened to 0.24 per cent from a February peak of 0.74, and the dollar rose 1.2 per cent against the yen *in the week* Japan hiked; yet the S&P added 0.7 per cent. **For a world-equity-plus-global-bond holding the verdict is: nothing happened, and that is the finding.** VWRA -1.03 per cent, the bond sleeve flat — no cushion and no second wound, because Treasuries sold off while JGBs rallied. Over a year, AGGU’s total return is **-0.23 per cent** against VWRA’s +17.54.⁴ Market explanation, not advice.

THE SCEPTIC · A GROWTH SHOCK DRESSED AS INFLATION, AND THE ANSWER TO IT

James E. Thorne of Wellington-Altus, on the day: “Rate hikes cannot produce oil, expand refining capacity, or repair disrupted supply routes.”⁵ The bull case is **Ben Snider** of Goldman Sachs: “we expect the bull market to continue.”⁵ **And the sceptic’s sceptic is the chair himself:** “We cannot affect any individual price... But what we can do, and will do, is ensure that any change in relative prices don’t broaden out.”¹ That is a coherent defence of tightening into a supply shock. Calling the result “credibility restored” is a judgement, not a reading.

SOURCES 1 FOMC decision, vote and projections from the Committee’s own materials of 16 September 2026; all chair quotations taken verbatim from the official press-conference transcript published by the Federal Reserve, extracted locally from the PDF rather than from any secondary summary. 2 Repricing, hike odds, the end-2027 implied rate and the Guha quotation from market reporting of 18 September; index, currency and commodity moves from a quote service read at source on 19 September, with bitcoin given as a range because no single settlement could be reconciled. 3 Bank of Japan decision, vote, both dissents, the outlook dissents and the named risks quoted verbatim from the Bank’s own 18 September statement PDF, extracted locally; the market reaction from the same day’s reporting. 4 VWRA, AGGU and their one-year total returns read at source on a listings service, 19 September 2026; the STI close cross-checked on two services; the gold all-time high read on the same commodity page. The corrections in the note are to this desk’s own No. 106. 5 Thorne via Stocktwits, 16 September; Snider via Bloomberg’s strategist survey carried on Yahoo Finance, 14 September. **This desk explains markets; it does not give investment advice.**

THE RABBIT HOLE • HAND-TOOL WOODWORKING

They call themselves Neanderthals, and most of them own a machine

A craft where the entry ritual is a single translucent shaving, the central scientific document is a Japanese microscope video from 1994, and the honest reason people do it has nothing to do with the furniture.

The difference is not nostalgia, it is what happens to the fibre. A machine removes wood by abrasion or many small high-speed cuts and leaves a surface you must sand. A sharp plane severs the fibre and leaves a burnished one that takes finish differently. That is the whole aesthetic argument.¹

The vocabulary is theirs and it is funny. Hand-tool purists are “**Neanderthals**”; the main forum’s hand-tool section is *Neanderthal Haven*. Power-tool woodworkers are “**Normites**”, after Norm Abram. The third category, which is what most of them are, is **hybrid**: machines rough out the stock, hand tools cut the joints and leave the final surface.

They admit it, on the record. **Rob Luter**: “My lunchbox planer quickly reduces the lumber to my desired rough thickness. I follow up with smoother planes... Could I do it all with my hand planes? Sure, but I just don’t have the time.” **Derek Cohen**, same thread: “If you want the best of all worlds, learn to master both groups of tools.”¹

THE MOMENT PEOPLE FALL IN — THREE OF THEM, ALL DOCUMENTED

The first shaving — a translucent, full-width curl off the mouth of a plane — needs no explaining. **The cap-iron video** is the community’s genuine conversion story. In 1994 Professor Chutaro Kato filmed a plane iron cutting with the chipbreaker set at varying distances behind the edge, showing that a cap iron set a few hundredths of a millimetre back bends the shaving and stops tear-out before it starts; the footage reached the American hand-tool world only in 2012.² **bill tindall**, January 2014: “I never planed much, well hardly at all. Never could avoid tear-out... now I don’t fear tear-out.”²

The first hand-cut dovetail is the third gateway, and it comes with its own correction, from **Edward**

Weber: “No one and I mean no one, cuts perfect dovetails on their first attempt.”³

6.19M / 194K

MEMBERS OF THE MASS WOODWORKING SUBREDDIT AGAINST THE HAND-TOOL ONE. THE NICHE INSIDE THE HOBBY IS ABOUT THREE PER CENT OF IT — AND THE ARGUMENT LIVES ON A FORUM WITH 3.27 MILLION POSTS⁴

THE CHATTER • WHY THEY DO IT, AND IT MAPS ONTO A SINGAPORE FLAT

Asked directly, in a thread called simply *Hand tools only*, the reasons are not romantic.

Oskar Sedell: “My shop is only about 5 by 11’, and with workbench, wood and tool storage there is no room for anything else.”¹

And the deepest version comes from a man who is otherwise this desk’s sceptic. **David Egerton-Warburton** chose hand tools “not because it helps me make better fine furniture but because it helps me make a better life” — meaning noise, dust and space.⁵

Five by eleven feet, no extraction, no neighbours complaining: there is not a sentence in that list that does not describe a spare room in a condominium.

Reddit was unreachable all session. Every voice on these three pages is a named handle on a forum, blog or maker’s page, with a date; the subscriber counts come from a third-party mirror.

THE SCEPTIC • SUPPLY, NOT DEMAND, IS THE CONSTRAINT

The usual way to write this piece is “a craft revival,” and the evidence offered is a market worth 28.5 billion US dollars — a figure covering hammers, pliers and screwdrivers, inside which this premium niche is a rounding error.⁴ Don’t use it.

The better indicator is what the flagship American maker had on the shelf on Friday: “We are out of stock of a number of tools right now.” Unavailable that day: the **No. 4 smoother in iron and bronze**, the **No. 5 jack**, the **No. 7 jointer**, the **No. 62 low-angle jack** — every plane a beginner is told to buy.⁶ Demand is not the problem. Castings are.

SOURCES 1 The hybrid admission and the reasons-for-hand-tools quotations from two Sawmill Creek threads, *Handplane vs Lunchbox* (2019) and *Hand tools only* (December 2019), read at source with handles and dates as posted. 2 Kato’s 1994 symposium presentation, the 2012 route into the US community, the translation credit and the tindall quotation from the Sawmill Creek thread on the history of the cap-iron studies, read at source. 3 Edward Weber, February 2023, in the Sawmill Creek thread on Rob Cosman’s dovetail video. 4 Subreddit membership figures are from a third-party Reddit mirror read 19 September 2026, because Reddit itself refused this desk; forum membership, thread and post counts read on Sawmill Creek’s own front page the same day; the market figure is MarketsandMarkets’ hand-and-woodworking-tools report, and is a whole-category number. 5 David Egerton-Warburton, “Hand Tool Virtue Signalling”, 2x3 Woodworking, 7 November 2023. 6 Lie-Nielsen Toolworks’ own tool-availability page and standard bench-plane listing, read 19 September 2026.

THE DEEP END · THE MAP, AND THE WARS

Four hundred dollars of plane, or ninety minutes with a car-boot Stanley

The community has been arguing about the same six questions for thirty years, in public, under real names, and the threads are still open.

The centre of gravity is not a subreddit. It is **Sawmill Creek**, an old-school forum where real names are required — 145,000 members, 3.27 million posts, and a hand-tool section whose thread index runs to 1,330 pages.

Names you will meet: **Derek Cohen** in Perth, the most-cited reviewer in the hobby; **Warren Mickley**, the traditionalist. Older still, and still alive: **The Old Tools mailing list**, a plain-text listserv running since the early 1990s, whose newest archived message when this desk read it was posted on **18 September 2026**.¹

THE RUNNING ARGUMENTS, ALL LIVE

Sharpening: freehand or jig. Rob Cosman uses a guide and a 16,000-grit stone, and sells “perfect dovetails, first attempt” alongside a US\$249–299 saw — on which **Derek Cohen**, 2023: “Rob is a great teacher, but he is also a salesman selling products.”³ The forum is unresolved and blunt about it. **Warren Mickley**: “Sellers himself seems to have a very poor concept of 30 degrees.” And²

Four hundred dollars, or ninety minutes. **Steven C Newman**, on restoring junk-shop Stanleys: “AVERAGE time in my shop...to when it is ‘work ready’...90 minutes.” **Stephen Rosenthal**, the other side: “I have many LN planes... superior to any older Stanleys, mostly because they come work ready.”⁴

THE GEAR, FROM THE METAL UP

Stanley’s Bailey numbers encode length and every maker since has copied them: **No. 4** is the smoother and the most-owned plane in the world, **No. 5** the jack, **No. 7** the twenty-two-inch jointer whose length averages out the hollows in a long edge.

The mechanism worth understanding is bevel direction. A **bevel-down** plane beds the iron at 45° with a chipbreaker on its face and an adjustable casting — the *frog* — supporting it; the cutting angle is fixed. A **bevel-up** plane beds the iron at 12° with no chipbreaker, so the angle is twelve degrees plus whatever you hone: grind 25° for end grain, grind 50° and you have 62° for interlocked tropical grain. **One**

body, three blades, three personalities — the sensible first plane in a small flat. And *chatter*, the washboard surface everyone blames on technique, is the iron vibrating under load, cured by mass. That thickness is most of what the money buys.

BENCH PLANES, READ AT SOURCE 19 SEP	PRICE
Melbourne Tool Co. low-angle jack	US\$215
WoodRiver No. 4 V3	US\$219.99
Quangsheng No. 4 bedrock (UK)	£170
Veritas low-angle jack, PM-VII	US\$299
Lie-Nielsen No. 4 smoother, iron	US\$375 backorder
Lie-Nielsen No. 7 jointer	US\$500 out of stock

THE CHATTER · ON THE CHINESE CLONE EVERYONE OWNS AND NOBODY QUITE TRUSTS

Derek Cohen, on WoodRiver against the premium pair: “the quality control is not have a patch on LN and Veritas. WR make a pretty decent product, but the LN and Veritas have an extra 10–20% improvement in quality.” And the specific fault gets named twice —⁵ **One clause for the Singapore reader.** The UK importer of the Quangsheng range states on every product page that it cannot ship to North America under a retail exclusivity. Asia is not restricted.⁶ The cheapest route to a serious plane runs east, not west.

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE BEGINNERS BURN MONEY

Sharpening is the money pit and the forum says so unprompted. The corrective, from **Chapel Eastland**: “Spend the \$100 bucks, get this stone...add a piece of leather for stropping and a green or white compound, and that’s all you need.” There is a published ceiling on grit almost nobody observes: **Stanley Covington** recommends 6,000 for striking chisels and 8,000 to 10,000 for plane irons, and says finer stones are not “truly cost effective.” Derek Cohen buys diamond stones from a discount marketplace “about \$8 each” and finds them serviceable.⁷

SOURCES 1 Forum membership and post counts, the front-page thread titles and the Old Tools archive’s most recent message read at source, 19 September 2026; the LumberJocks redirect verified by request. Two other boards returned 403 and nothing is attributed to them. 2 Sawmill Creek, *Convex bevel a la P. Sellers*, February 2015; YouTube subscriber counts read from the channel’s own page, 19 September 2026. 3 Sawmill Creek, *Rob Cosman video on cutting perfect dovetails first attempt*, February 2023. 4 Sawmill Creek, *Old vintage vs new tools*, April 2023. 5 Sawmill Creek, *WoodRiver vs Lie Nielsen block plane*, December 2018. 6 Prices read at source on 19 September 2026 at each maker’s or importer’s own site; Veritas prices read at a US dealer and at the Canadian site because Lee Valley’s US site rate-limited this desk. The North America shipping restriction is quoted from the importer’s own product pages. 7 Sawmill Creek, *Looking to get my 1st sharpening stones, Hesitate to ask a sharpening question and Which diamond plates in 2025*; stone prices read at retail, 19 September 2026.

THE DEEP END · THE GRAIL TIER, THE MONEY, AND NINETY DAYS

The grail tier: two hundred hours a plane, and an order book that is shut

At the top of this craft the constraint is not money. It is that one of the three men who matter has stopped answering.

Start with the bench, because nothing else works without it. It holds the work while you push a plane at it, and a bench that racks or skates is not a bench.

Four schools. The **Roubo**, from an eighteenth-century French treatise: a slab top four inches thick, legs flush with the front edge. The **Moravian**: knock-down, splayed legs, wedged tenons — the answer for a flat with a lift. A Nicholson costs about **US\$150** to build, a Roubo **US\$600**; the American maker's eight-foot bench is **US\$4,250¹** *plus a US\$400 crating fee*, and the vise hardware everyone wants is not available: **every line of that catalogue is sold out or on backorder.²**

US\$1,085

A MINIMUM VIABLE BUY-ONCE KIT: ONE BEVEL-UP JACK, FOUR CHISELS, A JAPANESE DOVETAIL SAW, ONE DIAMOND PLATE AND A STROP, A MARKING GAUGE, A SQUARE, AND A BENCH BUILT FROM PLANS³

Above that the ladder is steep: a comfortable kit about **US\$3,750**, an obsessive's over **US\$10,000**, the custom-heavy version **US\$25,000 to \$35,000 and a two-year wait.³**

THE MAKERS AT THE TOP, AND THEIR ORDER BOOKS

Karl Holtey, Sutherland, retired in 2015 and reappeared in 2019. His prices page, verbatim: "A plane may take in excess of two hundred hours of labour to complete... prices for the low angle planes start at around £2500 pounds and rise to around £7000 or more." **Konrad Sauer**, in Ontario, has **shut his order book** — "I have too much work... I needed to draw a line" — and takes no commissions at any price; **Bill Carter** still sells a bronze dovetailed thumb plane with boxwood infill at **£3,500.⁴**

Chris Vesper, Australia, makes the squares — a matched set of sliding bevels is **AUD 2,900**, and his rosewood handles are pre-ban stock: "CITES certification will have to be obtained at cost of the purchaser for any cross-border sales."⁴

The cutting edge now arrives from China at the top of the market. Zen-Wu Toolworks ships worldwide with a lifetime warranty. *Fine Woodworking* chopped

SOURCES 1 The Nicholson-versus-Roubo cost comparison from Sawmill Creek, *First bench build: Roubo or Nicholson*, read at source. 2 Bench and vise-hardware prices and stock status read on the makers' own sites, 19 September 2026. 3 The four-tier costings are this desk's arithmetic from the individually sourced prices on these pages; conversions are indicative. 4 Holtey's price statement, Sauer & Steiner's closed-book notice, Bill Carter's live stock list and Chris Vesper's accuracy specification and CITES note all read on each maker's own site, 19 September 2026. 5 *Fine Woodworking* no. 316, March/April 2025, Adam Godelt's chopping and plane-blade tests; *Popular Woodworking*, Logan Wittmer, 15 April 2026. 6 The camellia-oil comparison is *Fine Woodworking* no. 221, September/October 2011; humidity normal from the Meteorological Service Singapore; noise guidance from published Singapore renovation rules. 7 "Hand Tool Virtue Signalling", 2x3 Woodworking, 7 November 2023; Sawmill Creek threads *Hand tools only*, *The "rock-bottom"...hand tool addiction* and *Anything better than Lie-Nielsen?*. Reddit was unreachable throughout and is quoted nowhere on this desk.

hard maple: **1,200 chops** from its X-1 chisel against **800** for the reigning premium powder-metallurgy steel; and a year later *Popular Woodworking* on its **US\$69** chisels: they "may very well be the best bang-for-your-buck chisels available."⁵ Two independent tests a year apart, both on edge retention, both finding the newcomer ahead.

NINETY DAYS, IN A FLAT AT EIGHTY-TWO PER CENT HUMIDITY

Buy five things well: a bevel-up jack, with a second blade honed to fifty degrees for interlocked tropical grain; four chisels; a diamond plate and strop; a marking gauge; a square. Budget wins in three places: **Japanese saws** — a dozuki at about **US\$30** cuts dovetails as cleanly as a **US\$340** backsaw; the mallets you make yourself; a vintage jack body.

Rust is the whole game. *Fine Woodworking* tested camellia oil against four petroleum products: it "protect[ed] them best of all... the other oils also turned sticky and smelly."⁶

THE SCEPTIC · FROM INSIDE THE HOBBY, AND IT IS THE BEST WRITING IN IT

David Egerton-Warburton titled his essay "Hand Tool Virtue Signalling" and called the culture "virtue signalling with an undertone of superiority." "**Hand tools are not superior to power tools, real craft or woodwork as it was meant to be done.**"⁷ And the killer line, from the hand-tool forum's own pages — **Andrew Seemann**: "**There is no special prize for doing things the slowest and most difficult way possible.**" **Simon MacGowen's** three rules are the cure: let space be the constraint; buy only for a project, never a hypothetical one; sell an underused tool before buying a new one.⁷

NEXT DESCENTS

Knife making / bladesmithing — steel, heat treat and grind geometry.

Bookbinding & book repair — bone folders, linen thread, and an archival rabbit hole with no bottom.

Sourdough & home bread baking — flour, water and time, and a gear ladder that ends at a steel deck oven.

FITNESS · THE TRIAL AND THE CORRECTION, A FORTNIGHT APART

Three months of exercise missed its primary outcome. Two weeks earlier, the literature behind it was corrected

Fifty-two people aged forty-five to sixty-five, three sessions a week for twelve weeks. Mood moved. Cognition did not. And the stem-cell result came out with the wrong sign.

On Thursday a King's College London group published *NeuroFit* in *npj Aging*: a three-month randomised trial of aerobic and resistance exercise, three times a week, in fifty-two healthy adults aged **forty-five to sixty-five**.¹

The primary outcome was null. Pattern separation — the hippocampal memory task the trial was built around — produced $\beta = 0.33$ at $p = 0.26$.¹

Then the laboratory part. Participants' own serum went onto human hippocampal progenitor cells; the effect on the proportion of proliferating cells was $\beta = -0.23$, adjusted $p = 0.02$.¹ The exercisers' serum produced fewer proliferating stem cells, not more.

n = 52

UNBLINDED, WITH **NO ACTIVE CONTROL** — THE COMPARATOR GROUP RECEIVED NOTHING AT ALL, SO EXPECTANCY CONTAMINATES A SELF-REPORTED MOOD SCORE ENTIRELY¹

The other limits: the neurogenesis claim is an indirect proxy measured in a dish, and whether adult human hippocampal neurogenesis occurs at all remains contested — a 2018 *Nature* paper found it “drops sharply in children to undetectable levels in adults.”²

THE SCEPTIC · AND IT IS THE WHOLE LITERATURE, NOT THIS TRIAL

In July, a group led from Granada published a paper whose title is itself the argument: “**Running ahead of the evidence? Rethinking the exercise-cognition consensus after five decades of research.**”

The numbers come from the same team's umbrella review of twenty-four meta-analyses, which reports “low statistical power in the primary RCTs, selective inclusion of studies, publication bias.” The pooled benefit starts at $d = 0.22$; account for active controls and it falls to **0.13**; correct for publication bias and it becomes **0.05, interval -0.09 to 0.14** — zero.³

And **an author correction to that review appeared on 2 September 2026**, a fortnight before *NeuroFit* reported its null primary outcome.

THE CHATTER · THE INTENSITY ARGUMENT, IN ITS NATURAL HABITAT

The live discussion this month is about dose, not cognition. A *Cell Reports Medicine* paper on how intensity shapes the plasma proteome reached Hacker News on 11 September: “Muscle fibers and adipocytes were particularly sensitive to exercise intensity.”⁴ **asdfman123** gives the practitioner's synthesis: “High intensity by far gives you the best gains for the time you put in, but there's only so much you can do without overtraining.”⁴

THE WEARABLE ON YOUR FINGER

No. 106 printed a correction: the study everyone cited as validating sleep rings against clinical ECG had used a chest strap, and thirteen participants. Their headline figure: wearables are “**only 62% accurate at identifying sleep stages**” against polysomnography. They name Garmin and Polar for a “detailed and transparent approach.”⁵

None of which is a reason to stop training. It is a reason to train for the outcomes the evidence supports — strength, fitness, mood, function at seventy — and to treat “exercise makes you smarter” as a claim running ahead of its evidence. **General guidance, not medical advice.**

SOURCES ¹Farmand and colleagues; senior author Sandrine Thuret, “Effects of a three-month exercise programme on cognition, mood and neurogenesis: the *NeuroFit* randomised controlled trial”, *npj Aging*, 17 September 2026 (registration NCT05397990); design, sample and all three effect sizes read from the abstract via a public index because the publisher redirects this desk to an identity provider; the institutional interpretation from King's College London's own announcement of the same date. ²Sorrells and colleagues, *Nature*, 2018, on adult human hippocampal neurogenesis. ³Sanabria, Ciria, Holgado and colleagues, *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport*, 9 July 2026, quoted from the preprint abstract; the three effect sizes and the quoted methodological findings from the same team's umbrella review in *Nature Human Behaviour*, 27 March 2023; the author correction to that review was published 2 September 2026. ⁴Olsen and colleagues, *Cell Reports Medicine*, September 2026, abstract via a public index, the paper itself paywalled; Hacker News story 49653328, comments read at source, with the protocol summary attributed to the commenter. ⁵Dial, Hollander, Vatne, Emerson, Edwards and Hagen, “Contextual equivalence for accurate comparison of wearables requires transparency”, *Physiological Reports*, 15 December 2025, read in full. **General guidance only; not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGED

Four flights a day to Saigon, and twenty-six fewer flat beds

Singapore Airlines rebuilt its Vietnam winter on Wednesday. Frequencies to Ho Chi Minh City rise a third; total capacity falls three per cent and Business falls fourteen. Da Nang is the unambiguous win.

From 25 October, Singapore Airlines goes to four daily Ho Chi Minh City flights — twenty-one weekly services becoming twenty-eight, up a third. Read the seat count instead and the headline reverses.¹

Weekly seats fall from 6,489 to 6,286. Weekly Business seats fall from **798 to 686**, a fourteen per cent cut, because one rotation is downgauged from a 787-10 to a 737-8 MAX — ten Business seats where there were thirty-six. The new pair is a late-night play: 21:50 out of Singapore, 05:55 back.¹ More flights. Fewer flat beds. Both true, and only one was in the announcement.

Da Nang is the straightforward good news: three daily from the same date, fourteen weekly services becoming twenty-one, and capacity up fifty per cent in every cabin — Business from 140 weekly seats to 210.¹

686

WEEKLY BUSINESS CLASS SEATS TO HO CHI MINH CITY FROM 25 OCTOBER, DOWN FROM 798 — UNDER A HEADLINE THAT READS AS A THIRTY-THREE PER CENT EXPANSION¹

ENTRY AND PAPERWORK — ONE REAL CHANGE, AND IT IS FIVE DAYS OLD

Thailand halved its visa-free stay on 15 September. The sixty-day exemption has ended; sixty countries and territories including Singapore now get **thirty days**, tourism only. Land-border entries under the exemption are capped at twice a calendar year, though Singapore, Malaysia, Brunei and Indonesia are exempt from that cap.

Europe — delta only. The entry-exit system reached full deployment on 10 April; the travel authorisation is now scheduled for the last quarter of 2026, followed by six months in which nobody is refused entry for lacking one. The Commission's own page returned an empty body; those dates come from three law-firm summaries.²

SOURCES 1 Frequencies, seat and cabin counts and timings from the airline's schedule filing as reported by two aviation trade titles on 16 and 18 September 2026, read at source. 2 Thai visa-exemption change from the Tourism Authority of Thailand's own announcement of the gazetted rules, 15 September 2026; the European entry-exit and travel-authorisation dates from three government and law-firm summaries, flagged in the text because the Commission's own page served an empty body to this desk; Japanese departure tax and the Bali levy from their respective official and press sources. 3 Airline closure from the carrier's own scheme-of-arrangement page; route launches, the cabin programme and the EgyptAir announcement from the airlines' own releases and trade reporting, 12–19 September 2026; lounge openings and closures from operator announcements and the airline's own communications. 4 The quoted target and capacity figures are from the Land Transport Authority's own RTS Link project page, read 19 September 2026; every other milestone in circulation this week is reported rather than officially confirmed and is labelled as such. Terminal 5 status from published contract awards and programme statements.

Japan and Bali — delta only. Japan's departure tax tripled to ¥3,000 on 1 July, in the ticket price. Bali's levy is unchanged at 150,000 rupiah; enforcement is what changed — spot checks for the QR voucher, pay on the spot or be turned back. Compliance is around thirty-five per cent.²

ROUTES, CABINS, LOUNGES

Jetstar Asia is gone and should not be in anyone's route list. Operations ceased on 31 July 2025; all affected customers were refunded or rebooked.³

Now in the booking window: Madrid via Barcelona from 26 October — the first Madrid service in twenty-two years; Western Sydney International, daily, from 23 November; Riyadh, three times a week, from 1 December. **EgyptAir returns** with a Cairo–Singapore–Sydney service in early 2027 — no schedule, no on-sale date, and the fifth-freedom Singapore–Sydney rights unresolved, which is the entire commercial question.³

The new A350 First and Business have slipped to the first quarter of 2027 from Q2 2026, on supply-chain and seat-certification grounds. The S\$1.1 billion programme covers forty-one aircraft.³

Lounges. Changi Terminal 2's SilverKris Business side is due its second phase this month: thirty per cent more floor, a tended bar, nap recliners.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE JOHOR RAIL LINK, AND THE HONEST NUMBER

The RTS Link is the infrastructure item everyone wants a date for, and the only official statement this desk could read is the authority's own project page, which says exactly this and nothing more: the link "is targeted to commence passenger service at the end of 2026." Capacity ten thousand passengers an hour each way, journey time about five minutes.⁴ Everything else circulating — high-speed trials in April, Woodlands North completed on 4 September, ministerial remarks pointing at December — is reported and **not verifiable at an official source this week. Treat end-2026 as the target and early 2027 as the realistic number**, and do not book a January commute on it.

DEPARTURES · THE FUEL, THE POINTS, AND THE OPENINGS

Every airline in Asia has a surcharge now, and one does not

Jet fuel went from eighty-eight dollars a barrel in February to two hundred and nine in March. Cathay put thirty-four per cent on every passenger; Emirates went to a thousand dollars a leg in premium cabins. Singapore Airlines has charged passengers nothing.

The Strait of Hormuz has been effectively closed to normal commercial traffic since February, with a brief reopening in June that broke down in July. Eight transits on 13 September against a normal eighty-five a day (p3).¹

What that did to aviation is measurable. Asian jet fuel went from about US\$88 a barrel in mid-February to **US\$208.79 on 27 March**. The airline responses came in the second quarter: **Cathay Pacific** put a thirty-four per cent levy on every passenger from 1 April; **Thai Airways** ten per cent; **Emirates** up to US\$322 a leg in economy and **over US\$1,000 in premium cabins** to the Americas.¹

Singapore Airlines has imposed no passenger fuel surcharge at all — cargo only.¹ That is a genuine competitive fact, doing quiet work in every fare comparison a Singapore flyer makes this season. One caveat: this desk could not read a September jet-fuel print at source, and will not print a current number it has not seen.

LOYALTY — ONE WINDOW CLOSING, ONE THING TO IGNORE

A ten per cent Marriott transfer bonus runs to 30 September. Three thousand miles become 2,475 points — about 0.83 Singapore cents a mile against a standard 0.75, while the same programme's retail channel was offering roughly 1.25 cents in the same window. Worth doing only against a specific hotel redemption above about 1.5 cents a point, and irreversible.²

A redemption sale opened on 8 September — ten to fifteen per cent off Economy and Premium Economy Saver awards for travel between November and next May. And the delta not to re-explain: after last November's devaluation, the programme quietly repriced its mid-tier awards again in March — three per cent in First and Business, ten per cent in Economy.²

IN BRIEF

Moxy Niseko Village opened on 3 September — 310 rooms, genuine ski-in ski-out at the village gondola, two hours from New Chitose. A new eight-person gondola arrives in December, doubling uplift.³

SOURCES 1 Strait status and the 13 September transit count as on p3; the February and March jet-fuel prices and the three carriers' surcharge decisions from trade and wire reporting of the second quarter of 2026. No September jet-fuel print could be read at source and none is printed. 2 Transfer-bonus terms, the valuation arithmetic, the redemption sale and the March award repricing from a Singapore miles specialist's own reporting, read at source, and from the programme's own promotion pages. 3 Hotel opening and gondola plan from the operator's announcement of 3 September; rail-pass terms and the private-room service from the railways' own pages; Australian route additions from the carriers' announcements of 14–19 September; the aircraft letter of intent from the manufacturer's statement of 10 September. 4 Malaysian air-quality readings for 09:00 on 19 September 2026 from a Malaysian national outlet, read at source; the earlier Sabah readings from Borneo Post reporting of 4 September; the operator advisory quoted from a Sabah tour operator's own haze page, updated 2 September.

A Japanese autumn rail pass went on sale on Thursday — three consecutive days between 3 and 18 October. Read the exclusion before you buy: it does not cover Shinkansen or limited express. It is a local-line pass, not a substitute for the national one.³

THE CHATTER · AND THE HAZE, WHICH IS A TRAVEL FACT THIS WEEK

Transboundary smoke from Kalimantan is live across Malaysia and it matters to anyone flying into Borneo in the next fortnight. At nine on Saturday morning, twenty areas nationally were at unhealthy readings, down from thirty-two; the worst were **Kuching and Serian at 169**. In Sabah, only **Tawau, at 108**.⁴

The operators' line is that tours are not cancelled for haze, but that "haze may reduce visibility. Distant mountain views, islands, skylines and sunsets may appear less clear than usual."⁴ For a photographer that is the whole trip. **Diving is unaffected**, because the water does not care. Check the national index the morning you fly; it updates hourly (p21).

Reddit, FlyerTalk and TripAdvisor all refused this desk. Nothing on these four pages is quoted from any of them.

THE SCEPTIC · A FREQUENCY HEADLINE IS A MARKETING DOCUMENT

Go back to the top of the previous page and note the shape of it. "Four daily flights to Ho Chi Minh City, up thirty-three per cent" is true. So is "total capacity down three per cent, Business down fourteen." The first is the press release; the second required someone to multiply the seat map by the schedule.

The same trick is available in every direction this season. A lounge thirty per cent larger may have the same number of showers. A rail pass cheaper than the national one excludes the trains you would actually take. None of these is a lie. Each is a single number standing in for a service, and the number has been chosen.

The habit worth forming: when an airline announces frequencies, ask for seats; when it announces seats, ask which cabin.

30-DAY THAI STAY

NO SQ SURCHARGE

SABAH HAZE LIVE

RTS: TREAT AS 2027

THE GRAND TOUR • SABAH, MALAYSIAN BORNEO

You are not looking at wilderness from that boat

The animals are easy to see on the Kinabatangan because the forest is a ribbon a few hundred metres deep with a palm plantation behind it. It is one of the best wildlife river cruises on earth and one of the clearest pictures of habitat loss on earth, and it is the same photograph.

Two and a half hours from Changi, and chronically under-covered next to Borneo's Indonesian half. Start with the mechanism, because it explains both the wildlife and the discomfort.

Since the 1980s roughly **ninety per cent** of the Kinabatangan floodplain has been converted to oil-palm monoculture.¹ UNESCO declared a Kinabatangan Biosphere Reserve in September 2025 — **413,866 hectares** — and about **seventy-eight per cent of that reserve is planted with oil palm**.

What survives in the strip is not a remnant, it is a census: 127 mammal species, 315 birds, 100 reptiles — orangutan, pygmy elephant, proboscis monkey, sun bear, clouded leopard.¹

78%

SHARE OF THE 413,866-HECTARE UNESCO BIOSPHERE RESERVE THAT IS PLANTED WITH OIL PALM. THE HEADLINE NUMBER IS THE RESERVE; THE RESERVE IS MOSTLY PLANTATION¹

There is work against it, small and real: a 110-acre project where a women-led team has planted **more than 71,000 native trees over nearly six years**. And **John Payne** of the Bornean Rhino Alliance on what the UNESCO designation is actually for: "The main point... is to provide the area with a subjectively higher status than previously."¹

WHEN TO GO, AND WHERE TODAY SITS

Sabah has two weather systems and the guidebooks flatten them into one. The northeast monsoon, November to March, rains on the *east coast* — Sandakan, the Kinabatangan, Semporna; the southwest, May to September, on the *west*.

Today is a good window, with two live caveats. You are in the east-coast dry half and at the front of the

September–October diving shoulder, the one experienced divers prefer.² **Caveat one is the haze (p20):** Tawau was still at 108 on Saturday morning. Diving is unaffected. And one date is not negotiable: **Sipadan closes completely, 1–30 November, every year** — the commonest trip-planning error in the region.

THE CHATTER • THE PERMIT NUMBER ALMOST EVERY SOURCE GETS WRONG

Sabah Parks publishes no daily quota at all — only mechanics: booking up to six months ahead, fifty per cent deposit, forty-two registered operators.³ That vacuum is why the guides are all over the place. **120** is the pre-October-2022 cap, and an operator's own permit page was still publishing it on Friday. **176** was the 2020–22 allocation, and two 2026-dated guide sites still print it. The real figure, after thirteen more operators were admitted in October 2022, is **roughly 250 to 254 permits a day**.³ And a diver who posted a trip report in July 2025 described the island as "restricted to a maximum of 200 divers per day." A third wrong number, from a first-hand witness.⁴

THE SCEPTIC • THE ORANGUTAN GUARANTEE IS MARKETING

Honest hit rates over a **three-night** Kinabatangan stay: proboscis monkeys near-certain on every dawn cruise, the most reliable primate sighting in Southeast Asia; macaques, langurs and hornbills near-certain. **A wild orangutan is not a daily event** — good over three nights, a coin-toss over one. **A pygmy elephant is the lottery**.⁵ Sepilok is the other correction. It is genuinely a rehabilitation centre — which is *why* it can disappoint: the animals furthest along the programme stop turning up at the platform. **And nobody leads with the better hour.** The sun bear centre shares the same entrance, costs RM 50 and has a fraction of the crowds — and the Bornean sun bear is a genuinely strange, under-photographed animal.⁵

SOURCES 1 Conversion figures, the 1982–2014 forest-cover loss, the biosphere reserve's area and oil-palm share, the land-tenure split, the species counts, the one-kilometre corridor recommendation, the two reforestation projects and both quotations from environmental reporting of the September 2025 UNESCO designation and the underlying conservation literature, read at source. 2 Monsoon structure, the diving-season shape and the November closure from Sabah travel and diving references read at source, September 2026; the crowding assessment from a Sabah guide updated 21 August 2026. 3 Booking mechanics, deposit terms and the operator count read on Sabah Parks' own diving page, 19 September 2026; the obsolete 120 figure read the same day on a current operator's live permit page; the 250–254 range from three independent 2025–26 sources, traceable to the October 2022 expansion from twenty-four to thirty-seven operators; the three-dive change from the operator's own 2026 update, with no primary Sabah Parks announcement readable. 4 ScubaBoard trip report, July 2025, read at source. 5 Sighting probabilities, feeding times, admission prices and opening hours from the centres' own pages and from operator and visitor accounts read at source. Reddit, TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk all refused this desk; nothing here is attributed to them.

THE GRAND TOUR · SABAH, THE PRACTICAL HALF

The mountain and the island do not fit in the same fortnight

Getting there, where to sleep, what it costs, and the one certification rule that decides the shape of a family trip.

Three carriers fly Singapore to Kota Kinabalu non-stop, every day — Scoot, AirAsia and Batik Air Malaysia — twenty to thirty services a week, from 06:20 to 17:55, at a block time of two hours twenty.¹

Fares read on Friday range from a US\$157 return to US\$184 on Scoot. **The working number is S\$220–300 return per person for September–October, S\$350–450 in July and August.**¹

The onward legs are short: Sandakan about six flights a day, Tawau about eleven at fifty-five minutes.

THE TRANSFERS, HONESTLY TIMED	REAL DURATION
Sandakan → Sukau, overland	~2 h
Tawau airport → Semporna	1 h 15 – 2 h
Semporna → Mabul, by boat	~45 min
Lahad Datu → Danum Valley, 82 km	2 – 2.5 h

The last is logging road and dirt. **The pace killer on this trip is the internal transfers, not the activities.**¹

SIPADAN, THE MECHANICS THAT DECIDE EVERYTHING

Individuals cannot apply. A non-Malaysian pays RM 450 per person per Sipadan day — RM 350 permit plus RM 100 conservation fee, or **S\$140.65 per diver per day before a single tank**; Malaysians pay RM 300.²

Nobody stays overnight on Sipadan. Every dive there is a day trip — from Mabul, Kapalai or Semporna.

THE SCEPTIC · THE CERTIFICATION RULE THAT RESHAPES A FAMILY TRIP

Sipadan requires **Advanced Open Water**, a Sabah Parks rule since October 2022; Junior Advanced can be held from twelve, so on paper a twelve-year-old qualifies.²

The operator's own depth table caps twelve-to-fourteens with Advanced at twenty-one metres, and Sipadan's signature wall dives run eighteen to thirty.²

So she can legally dive Sipadan and will spend every dive above the group and above the action. Certify her at Mabul instead — the muck sites are shallow and world-class — and take the permits yourself.³

THE MOUNTAIN, THE FOOD, AND THE MONEY

Mount Kinabalu, 4,095m — and yes, a fit twelve-year-old can do it. Two days, one night at Panalaban; single-day climbs have not been permitted since 2015, and **the permit is tied to your bed.** Non-Malaysian adult fees come to about RM 800 before accommodation, and the **guide ratio is one to two for under-sixteens.** A budget package is about S\$560 a head; **there is no published minimum age**, and operators put the floor at ten.⁴

Eat Sabahan, not Malaysian. *Ngiu chap*, the Hakka-Hainanese beef-and-offal noodle soup, is Kota Kinabalu's defining bowl at about RM 9; *hinava*, raw mackerel cured in lime with grated bambangan seed. At the seafood market: **agree the price before it goes on the grill.**⁵

Malaria is location-specific. Transmission is in rural forested areas, with the macaque parasite *Plasmodium knowlesi* — Danum Valley and the Kinabatangan corridor precisely. Kota Kinabalu, the islands, Semporna and Mabul are **not** malaria settings. Take the forest legs to a travel doctor: **a pointer to the CDC's advice, not medical advice from this desk.**⁶

\$S\$9,000–13,000

TEN DAYS, TWO ADULTS AND A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD, MID-TIER KINABATANGAN LODGE AND FOUR NIGHTS' DIVING AT MABUL WITH TWO SIPADAN DAYS — BUILT FROM VERIFIED COMPONENT PRICES, NOT A QUOTED PACKAGE⁷

And the sentence that shapes the itinerary: Kinabalu does not fit in the same trip as Sipadan unless you have fourteen days. A realistic ten-day shape is Kota Kinabalu one night, Sandakan and Sepilok one night, **three on the Kinabatangan**, then Semporna and Mabul for four.⁷

SOURCES 1 Carriers, frequencies and block time from route data cross-read on two booking platforms, 19 September 2026; fares from two route pages read the same day and printed as a range because they differ; the regional carrier's rebrand from the acquisition announcement. Exchange rate mid-market, 19 September 2026. 2 Permit allocation mechanics, minimum-stay structures, fees, booking lead times, the day-trip position, the certification requirement and the operator's published depth table all read at source on Sabah Parks' and the operators' own pages, 19 September 2026. 3 ScubaBoard, quoted comments of April and June 2024 and July 2025, read at source with handles and dates as posted. 4 Climb structure, fees, guide ratios and package prices read on the permit operator's own booking pages; via ferrata age limits from the operator's own rules. 5 Dishes, named establishments and price sense from Sabah food writing and review platforms read at source. 6 US CDC destination page for Malaysia, dated 25 August 2026, read at source; the UK and Singapore equivalents were unreachable. 7 The budget is this desk's construction from the individually sourced components above and is labelled as such.

THE DIARY • THE DATED AGENDA

Sumo went on sale yesterday morning, and the one hard deadline on this page is ten days away

Every row below was re-checked against a promoter, a venue or an official ticketing page before it was printed. One price set belongs to a different year, and one museum closes in eleven days for nineteen months.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW • PLAN AHEAD

30 SEP ★ **MJ The Michael Jackson Musical — public on sale, 10am**
SANDS THEATRE • EARLY-BIRD PRICING ENDS 30 OCT. **THE ONE HARD DEADLINE HERE**²

30 SEP ★ **Snow City — the last day, after twenty-six years**
21 JURONG TOWN HALL ROAD • CLOSING PERMANENTLY • THE FAREWELL SNOW PLAY PACKAGE IS **\$19 / \$16**¹

9–11 OCT ★ **F1 Singapore Grand Prix — the first Sprint weekend**
MARINA BAY • **MOST MULTI-DAY GRANDSTANDS SOLD OUT**; WHAT IS LEFT IS FRIDAY-ONLY, \$198–398¹

26–29 NOV ★ **The Nutcracker — State Ballet of Georgia**
SANDS THEATRE • SIXTY DANCERS UNDER NINA ANANIASHVILI • **FROM \$78**²

13–22 NOV ★ **Singapore Writers Festival — “Hidden in Plain Sight”**
BRAS BASAH.BUGIS • FESTIVAL PASS \$30 → **\$21** WITH THE CULTURE PASS²

4 & 12 DEC ★ **Two Door Cinema Club, then Slowdive**
FORT CANNING GREEN • TDCC 4 DEC, \$168 • SLOWDIVE 12 DEC, \$158 — ONE LISTINGS SITE WRONGLY SAYS THE 21ST • **NO UNDER-12S**³

13–14 DEC ★ **The Geminids — and a new moon four days earlier**
ANYWHERE DARK • **MIDNIGHT TO ABOUT 5.30AM** ON THE 13TH INTO THE 14TH⁴

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

8–22 NOV ★ **Kyushu Basho — general sale opened yesterday**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER • THE UNPUBLISHED ON-SALE TIME IS ANSWERED: **10:00 JST, 19 SEP**⁵

29 NOV–11 DEC ★ **Koyo — and 2026 is late everywhere**
THE 2 SEPTEMBER FORECAST HAS MAPLES PEAKING **TOKYO 29 NOV, KYOTO 11 DEC — SIX DAYS LATE. KYOTO'S MAPLES ARE A DECEMBER TRIP THIS YEAR.**⁷

9 SEP–13 DEC ★ **Masterpieces of the Renaissance from the Louvre**
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO • ¥2,400 • **THE LAST WEEK, 7–13 DEC, IS TIMED-ENTRY ONLY**⁶

7–8 NOV ★ **Super GT — two final races in one weekend**
MOBILITY RESORT MOTEGI • ON SALE SINCE 6 SEPTEMBER⁶

2–3 DEC ★ **Chichibu Yomatsuri — winter fireworks and six floats**
CHICHIBU, SAITAMA, NINETY MINUTES FROM TOKYO⁶

30–31 JAN ★ **HSBC SVNS Singapore 2027 — dates locked**
THE KALLANG • ON WORLD RUGBY'S 2027 CALENDAR • **TICKETS NOT YET ON SALE**⁸

PLANNING NOTES • TWO CLOSURES AND ONE WRONG PRICE SET

Gone at face value. BTS's four December nights — the correction printed in No. 106 — are **sold out on every official channel**.²

Close your Tokyo science day. Miraikan — not the Ghibli Museum, as reporting this month had it — **closes on 1 October until 22 April 2027.**⁶

A price set from a different year. The HK\$2,250 and HK\$1,100 prices circulating against the Hong Kong Sevens are the 2026 edition's.⁸

And still held, a third issue running: Gardens by the Bay has published no Christmas Wonderland listing for 2026. We will not print a date we cannot see.¹

SOURCES 1 Snow City closure and package from the operator's own announcement; Grand Prix session times from the championship's race hub, and ticket inventory, prices and entertainment from the promoter's own pages, all read 19 September 2026; Gardens by the Bay items from its own calendar of events. 2 The musical's on-sale ladder is confirmed on two independent trade reports because the venue's own site returned 503 three times; the ballet's dates and company are firm and its ceiling price is secondary-sourced, so only the floor is printed; Joji, the writers' festival and the BTS sold-out status read on the promoters' and festival's own pages. 3 Slowdive's date, prices and the under-12 bar read at the promoter's own page, which contradicts a widely-syndicated listing; Two Door Cinema Club is promoter-sourced because the ticketer renders client-side. 4 Peak timing converted to Singapore time and the moon phase are solid; the hourly rate is indicative, because three astronomical references refused this desk. No eclipse is visible from Singapore in this window. 5 On-sale time, prices, fees, collection rules and the box-office window read on the official sumo ticketing pages, Japanese and English; the absence of a sold-out notice is stated as an absence, not as availability. 6 Exhibition dates, hours and admission from each museum's own site; circuit dates from the circuit's own English page; the museum closure from Tokyo listings reporting of August 2026. 7 The Japan Meteorological Corporation's own koyo release of 2 September 2026; Tokyo and Osaka quoted from the release, the rest from a published table of it. 8 World Rugby's 2027 schedule and the Australian Open's own newsroom; the Hong Kong price set is identified to the 2026 edition it belongs to.

THE TABLE • SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

One bowl, two meals — and a tower of chopped tuna that splits the room on price

Five openings, none previously covered here. One is genuinely settled, two are early-warm, one is eight days old, and one is honestly too new to judge.

MUKAI, in the basement of Plaza Singapura, opened on 26 August as the Tokyo original's first outlet outside Japan. The house move is not sashimi: the seafood is *chopped* and mounded into a tower over rice — the *kaiho don*, “sea treasure” bowl — and you choose your rice and vinegar before it is built.¹

Then the ritual that makes it worth the trip: eat half, and have warm dashi — katsuobushi or asari clam — poured over the rest to finish it as ochazuke. Bowls run S\$19.90 to S\$79.90; the entry Nami is S\$28.90.

And the reception is divided, on price rather than craft. One reviewer scored it three and a half out of five, praised the ochazuke ritual, then landed squarely: the fish “didn’t have a strong, sweet flavour,” soy sauce was doing the lifting, and they “wished the fish quality could be better, especially for the steep price point.” Another liked the fatty tuna but flagged briny uni, and advised tempering expectations because **the Tokyo original is itself “slightly overhyped.”**¹ Genuinely interesting; not yet genuinely loved.

THE CHATTER • THE SETTLED ONE, AND THE BIGGEST SMOKER IN SOUTHEAST ASIA

Decker Barbecue opened its flagship in the conserved 1956 Old Bukit Timah Fire Station on 7 August — a **fourteen-foot, three-tonne offset smoker shipped from Texas, the only one in Southeast Asia**, running meat for up to twelve hours and visible from the room.²

This is the one on the page actually reviewed rather than previewed. Time Out: “worth the trip west even if you’ve never made it to Robertson Quay.” A second reviewer praised the brisket and the sauce station, with one clean criticism: the pizza dough was “rather lacklustre” for the price.² **Weekday reservations only; weekends are walk-in.**

Elijah Pies opened its Joo Chiat flagship on 12 September — eight days old at press, sixty seats in a

restored 1930s Peranakan shophouse fitted by the studio behind Odette.³

The swing is savoury: a line of *pizza pies* on a flaky croissant-style crust the brand claims as Singapore’s first, at S\$23–24, alongside an outlet-exclusive soufflé pie at S\$18, baked to order with a twenty-minute wait and molten gianduja inside. The dissent is in the back catalogue, where the group’s Tanjong Pagar shop draws a recurring “pricey treats” complaint. **Loved on arrival, unproven on consistency.**³

Two more, briefly. **Bari Bari Grand**, in the arcade at the Capitol since 9 August, is a Hong Kong mall-queue teppan concept going upmarket for the first time: A4/A5 Miyazaki wagyu, a 150g ribeye at S\$75, and a **lobster and wagyu hamburger at S\$49** that one reviewer’s table made its unanimous favourite. **Early-warm, not settled.**⁴ And **Kali Kali**, a bagel bakery off Lavender Street since 25 August, whose hook is a buttery crust borrowed from shio pan. One reviewer made the avo and lox its top pick — “a real banger” — and flagged the catch: **the food court has no air conditioning and fills at lunch. Too new to judge, and printed as such.**⁵

THE HONESTY LEDGER • NOBODY WRITES THE FAREWELL ROUND-UPS

Carnivore closes at the end of this month, after twenty years. The Brazilian churrascaria opened in 2005 and ran six outlets.⁶

Note what did not happen. Two openings on this page drew four write-ups each inside a week; the closing drew one news item. **The asymmetry is the point:** the coverage machine is built to announce, not to account. And the one we are still holding: **Árō** on Mohamed Sultan Road has been trailed as “opening in September” since early July, and publishes no date, menu or booking line. We will wait for a plate.⁶

PLAZA SINGAPURA JOO CHIAT CITY HALL
BUKIT TIMAH BENDEMEER

SOURCES 1 Opening date, format, the ochazuke service, prices and the walk-ins policy read on the restaurant’s own site and its Singapore opening coverage; the two review verdicts quoted from the publications that filed them, read at source. 2 Opening date, the building, the group acquisition, the smoker specification and the price list read on the restaurant’s own menu page and the Time Out and HungryGoWhere reviews. 3 Opening date, the fit-out and studio credit, the menu and prices from the flagship’s opening coverage across four Singapore titles; the back-catalogue complaint is characterised from recurring reader commentary on the group’s earlier outlet. 4 Opening date, group, provenance and prices from the venue’s own directory listing and the one substantive review published to date; the promotional window is dated and identified as closed. 5 Opening date, menu and the quoted verdict and caveat from the single substantive review, read at source. 6 Closure announcement of 14 July 2026 and the buffet prices from Singapore news reporting; the Árō position verified by the absence of any published opening date, menu or reservation line on the restaurant’s own channels as of 19 September 2026. Reddit’s Singapore food community was unreachable and nothing here is attributed to it.

THE UNDERCURRENT · BHUTAN

Forty-eight of them carried it back up the mountain

Bhutan built the best-designed wild-harvest market in the Himalaya: open auctions, published prices, policed permits. This summer the auctions stopped clearing. In the customs file underneath, the country had shipped thirty-nine per cent more of the stuff for fifteen per cent less money.

It grows above four thousand metres, and it is a fungus that has eaten a caterpillar. *Ophiocordyceps sinensis* infects a ghost-moth larva underground, mummifies it, and in early summer sends a thin dark stalk up through the head. In Dzongkha it is **Yartsa Goenbub** — summer grass, winter worm. In Bhutan’s customs tariff it is line 12119050, measured in grams.

On the twenty-sixth of July, at the auction ground in Damji in Gasa district, **fifty-five sellers** brought their harvest down from Lunana and Khamaed. Nearly thirty buyers bid. **Six sellers accepted. Forty-eight refused and took it home.**¹

The top bid for the best grade was 3.6 million ngultrum a kilogram. Mindu, from Lunana: “I withdrew my cordyceps because the price offered was even lower than what local traders were offering.” Jigme had expected 3.8 to 3.9 million; “the highest offer was only around Nu 2.5 M, so I decided not to sell.” The elected head of Lunana, Gup Kaka: “The price today is much lower compared to what we received in the past five years.”¹

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SELLERS AT THE DAMJI AUCTION WHO REFUSED EVERY BID AND CARRIED THE HARVEST BACK — AN EIGHTY-SEVEN PER CENT WALKOUT, AT THE COUNTRY’S MOST IMPORTANT CORDYCEPS SALE¹

It was not one bad room. At Choekhor in Bumthang a fortnight earlier the benchmark fell from 2.7 million to 2.5. Jamyang Chophel, who cannot afford to withhold: “As farmers, we cannot afford to take it elsewhere. So, I am thinking of selling it after the auction” — outside the state market, which is the whole problem.¹ And a buyer supplied the other half: exporting “has become more challenging... demand has declined.”¹

SOURCES 1 The Damji auction — seller and buyer counts, the withdrawal figure, the bid levels and the Mindu, Jigme, Kaka and Dendup quotations — from Bhutan Broadcasting Service’s report of 26 July 2026, read at source; the Choekhor auction and the Jamyang Chophel quotation from the same broadcaster, 13 July 2026; the Sephu withdrawal from Kuensel Online, 15 July 2026. 2 Gup Kaka’s account of farm-gate purchasing and the 2024 seller and bidder counts from Bhutan Broadcasting Service, 29 July 2024, read at source. 3 Volumes, values and destinations read directly from *Bhutan Trade Statistics 2025* (Department of Revenue and Customs, Ministry of Finance, published February 2026) and *Bhutan Trade Statistics 2024*, tariff line 12119050, both PDFs extracted and tabulated locally. The 2025 table contains one line — twenty-five grams to the Czech Republic at a unit value roughly thirty times the next highest — that is almost certainly a coding error; the aggregate is given both as printed and with that line excluded. The absence of diplomatic relations is from both foreign ministries’ own releases.

“Buyers are sending their people to our village directly and buying around 30 per cent of cordyceps from our village itself.” — Gup Kaka of Lunana, 2024

He said that two years ago, describing the auction’s slow leak: thirty per cent bought at the farm gate before the sale, and there “the buyers collude among themselves and drastically lower the prices.”² The auction has been thinning for years. This summer is when it stopped clearing.

THE NUMBER UNDERNEATH, WHICH NOBODY HAS PUBLISHED

CORDYCEPS EXPORTS	2024	2025
Volume	176.0 kg	245.0 kg
Value (Nu m)	100.0	87.6
Unit value (Nu/kg)	568,000	345,000
Thailand	83.7 kg	100.3 kg
Viet Nam	75.3 kg	96.0 kg
China	73 g	nil

Volume up 39.1 per cent. Value down 12.4 per cent as printed, or 15.4 per cent excluding one implausible line. Average unit value down 39.2 per cent. Total 2025 value is about one million US dollars.³

Thirty-nine per cent more fungus. Fifteen per cent less money. That is the scissors, and it is the whole story in two rows.

And then the last line of the table, a different story altogether. **Bhutan sells the most Chinese luxury good on earth to countries that are not China**, because it cannot sell it to China: seventy-three grams in 2024, nothing in 2025. The two have no diplomatic relations and no direct trade link. Thailand and Vietnam took eighty per cent of last year’s tonnage, and what they are is *entrepôts*.³

THE UNDERCURRENT · CONTINUED

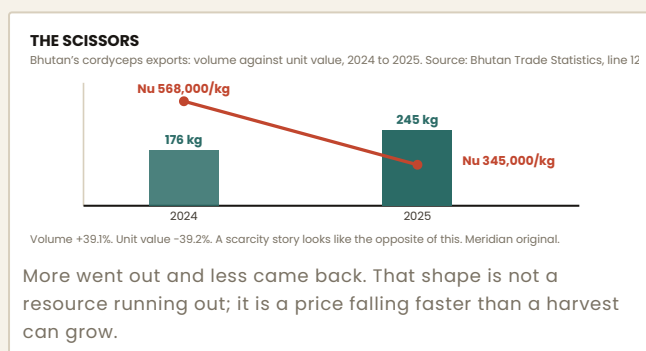
A royal decree gave them a market instead of a business

Before 2004 collecting it was smuggling. After 2004 it was national development policy, and it worked so well that eighty per cent of the households stopped keeping yaks.

On 17 June 2004 a royal decree permitted limited collection by the yak herders whose animals had always grazed those pastures, reversing a total ban.¹

Measure the success honestly. A peer-reviewed survey of 132 household heads in Laya and Lunana found the caterpillar fungus “the major source of income for highland communities which overtook the yak farming practices since its legalization in 2004,” and that **more than eighty per cent of households have abandoned yak farming.**²

Lunana is 810 people in 185 households at about 3,400 metres; the district lists its economy, in full, as cordyceps and livestock.³ There is no second crop at four thousand metres. The same survey found ninety-one per cent saying climate change threatens the fungus, and eighty-five per cent reporting **mosquitoes newly present in the highlands.**²



Which kills the easy explanation. The obvious story is depletion — the fungus is running out, prices reflect scarcity. And supply is falling: the 2023 Bhutanese harvest came in at 118 kilograms, down eighty-two per cent. Nepal's Karnali transport permits fell from 2,414 kilograms in 2018–19 to **941** last year.⁴

But 2025's volume rose thirty-nine per cent while its value fell. **That is not a scarcity signature.** Scarcity raises unit values. This is demand withdrawing faster than supply.

AND IT IS REGIONAL, WHICH KILLS THE OTHER EASY EXPLANATION

Nepal, same season. Bulk yarsagumba is fetching 1.6 to 1.8 million rupees a kilogram against 2.7 million two years ago. Lanka Bahadur Rokaya: **“If we can't earn from herbs, our only option is India.”** This is not a Bhutanese auction problem. It is a price break across the whole Himalayan supply.

Two further facts complete the demand side, both from this year. **The substitute is winning:** cultivated *Cordyceps militaris* is projected at 62.4 per cent of the strain market in 2026, in a category still growing. The wild farmgate is falling inside a rising market.⁵ And in May, researchers at an Indian agricultural university identified *Cordyceps* in the **low-altitude** forests of Arunachal Pradesh. Bhutan's own environment ministry flagged the risk to a premium fungus economy that rests entirely on altitude scarcity.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THIS DESK'S OWN NUMBER IS SOFT

The composition problem is real and should be printed with the finding. A thirty-nine per cent fall in average unit value is value divided by volume. If the extra tonnage in 2025 was disproportionately low-grade, part of that fall is a mix effect — and the customs line has no quality sub-code, so it cannot be decomposed. What corroborates it is that the auction floors and the Nepali farmgate point the same way. **“Highest bid” is not a clearing price.** With eighty-seven per cent of sellers refusing, the top bid is a reserve-price story. And the grade labels themselves moved, so the Bumthang comparison is not like for like. **A third to forty per cent of the trade never enters the auction at all,** so auction data under-describe the market in both directions. **And everybody quoted has an interest.** Collectors gain from insisting last year's price was four million; it strengthens the case for a floor. Buyers gain from “exporting has become more challenging”; it is also the perfect justification for a low bid. And the government gains from a climate framing, which attracts adaptation finance, over a policy framing, which would say the state built a monoculture at four thousand metres and never diversified it.

SOURCES 1 The Royal Decree of 17 June 2004 and its reversal of the prior ban, from Bhutanese reporting and from the regional policy literature on the Bhutanese cordyceps regime. 2 Dorji, Yangzom, Norbu, Rinchen, Dorjee and Tenzin, “Understanding the impact of climate change and resilience among highlanders in northern parts of Bhutan: A case study in Gasa district”, *PLOS Climate* 2(4): e0000079, 6 April 2023; survey of 132 household heads in Laya and Lunana, quotations and percentages from the paper. 3 Population, household and village counts and the stated economy from the Gasa district administration's own Lunana profile. 4 The 2023 Bhutanese harvest figure from Kuensel; the Nepali prices, permit volumes, named collectors' earnings, the early-departure share and the altitude-sickness deaths from The Kathmandu Post, Krishna Prasad Gautam, 13 July 2026, read at source. 5 Cultivated-strain market share and category forecasts from published market research, cited as such; the Arunachal Pradesh low-altitude identification from Indian regional press of 6–7 May 2026 and the Bhutanese ministry's response from Kuensel, 5 June 2026.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE PRECEDENT, AND THE ARGUMENT

Six thousand farmers tried this in Kentucky in 1904, and the pool leaked at the farm gate

The Black Patch growers pooled the crop and refused to sell. What broke them was not the monopoly's strength but its willingness to pay the holdouts' neighbours more.

On 24 September 1904, five to six thousand dark-fired tobacco farmers assembled at Guthrie, in Todd County, Kentucky, and formed a planters' protective association. They faced a single buyer, and leaf had fallen to four to six cents a pound — below the cost of production. Membership reached roughly thirty thousand at its 1905 peak.¹

The trust refused to negotiate. Then it did the thing that breaks every producer pool: **it paid non-members conspicuously more.**¹

Individual withholding fails. Organised pooling sometimes works. What usually works is a legal instrument, and Bhutan has none available.

Read Damji through that. **Each of the forty-eight Lunana sellers is a holdout by structure, not by choice.** And the leak is documented by the district's own elected head: thirty per cent of the harvest bought by agents in the village before the auction opens.²

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS — AND THE BREAK IS THE ARGUMENT

The trust was extracting; Bhutan's buyers are not. In 2026 end-demand genuinely fell — Nepal's farmgate down a third, a cultivated substitute taking the category. **You cannot strike against an absence of buyers.**

Tobacco stores; cordyceps degrades and grades down. And there is no antitrust remedy: Kentucky's instrument was a federal court against a domestic monopolist; Bhutan's problem is a foreign demand curve reached through third countries.

THE ARGUMENT

Bhutan did everything the development orthodoxy asks: it formalised an informal trade, created a

market, published the price, policed the permits.³ What the highlanders got was **transparency without leverage:** perfect information about a price they cannot change, a well-policed quotation of how little the world now wants what they have, delivered in a field, once a year, after it is already dug up. **Transparency is not bargaining power. It is a better view of the fall.**

There is a harder version underneath. The 2004 decree converted the world's highest pastoral economy into a single-commodity export economy — one product, one month, no brand — and the state's answers are all market design. None touches the fact that Bhutan ships an *undifferentiated commodity* into a market where the differentiated substitute is winning.

Which makes the sharpest criticism of the government not environmental but commercial — and it has a date. On **10 June 2026** Bhutan launched a national geographical-indication system and registered its first four products: yathra cloth, Bumthang honey, a buckwheat flour, a yak cheese.⁴ **Cordyceps — the country's largest agricultural export by value, genuinely wild, genuinely Bhutanese — was not among them.** Four months later the auctions stopped clearing.

A critic would say the highlanders' problem is not that the market betrayed them, but that nobody has done the boring commercial work: the direct channel to Hong Kong and Singapore that would let a Bhutanese kilogram be told apart from anyone else's.

One more thing, built out of the failure of the old economy: six founders in Laya have opened a lodge. It acquired its urgency, they say, when their horseman's wife nearly died of altitude sickness while collecting cordyceps.⁵ The replacement for the cash crop, if there is one, is a hotel. It is, at least, a second thing.

SOURCES 1 The Guthrie meeting, the attendance range (sources give five and six thousand and both are printed as a range), the leaf price, the pooling strategy, the membership figures, the trust's premium to non-members, the raids and the 1908 lynching, the April 1908 arrests and the 1911 antitrust dissolution, from the standard histories of the Black Patch tobacco wars and the state encyclopaedia and legislative accounts of the period. 2 Gup Kaka's farm-gate figures, Bhutan Broadcasting Service, 29 July 2024, as on p25. 3 Enforcement figures — 191 illegal collectors encountered, 2,383 cordyceps seized, operations 11 May to 8 June 2026, thirty police deployed — from Kuensel Online, 22 August 2026. 4 The national geographical-indication launch of 10 June 2026 and the first four registered products from Bhutan Broadcasting Service and the responsible ministry's own announcement. 5 The Laya lodge and the account of its founding from TIME's World's Greatest Places 2026 entry, read at source. Chinese wholesale price movement is directional corroboration from a Chinese origin-price board and trade reporting, and is not a like-for-like comparison with Bhutanese grades. This desk found no verifiable Bhutanese social-platform discussion of the auctions and has invented none.

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

What the average hides

A whole issue of correct numbers that were not about the thing you wanted to know. At six o'clock on Saturday the island's haze index read 108 and the air read 61, and the agency publishes both on purpose. A compressed language model kept 98.2 per cent of its ability, averaged across twenty tests, two of which fell by a quarter. A school programme was "fifty per cent more effective" in two hundred and five children and did nothing measurable in the other 1,588.

Eight ships passed through Hormuz on the thirteenth, against eighty-five in a normal week — and Saudi volumes through it doubled, because the hulls carrying the difference had their transponders off. A global bond index finished the week flat while Treasuries sold off and Tokyo rallied. Four hundred and thirteen thousand hectares became a UNESCO reserve, and seventy-eight per cent of it is oil palm.

And in Bhutan, forty-eight of fifty-five collectors refused the bid and carried the harvest back up the mountain — in a country whose own customs file shows it shipped thirty-nine per cent more of the stuff last year for fifteen per cent less money. They have an open auction, a published price and no leverage at all. Transparency is not bargaining power. It is a better view of the fall.

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A note on method. This edition was researched with working network access, and the load-bearing figures were read on the pages that carry them — the Federal Reserve's own press-conference transcript and the Bank of Japan's decision document, both extracted locally; Bhutan's customs PDFs for 2024 and 2025; the National Environment Agency's advisory; the journals themselves; Sabah Parks' own diving page; and each maker's own price list. **Reddit was unreachable on every path all session, so nothing anywhere in this book is attributed to it;** every community voice here is a named handle on Sawmill Creek, Hacker News, HardwareZone, ScubaBoard, The Fedora Lounge, Letterboxd, Permanent Style or a maker's own comment thread, with a date. TripAdvisor, FlyerTalk, Styleforum, Head-Fi, Hodinkee and a long list of publishers also refused this desk, and are named on the pages where they would otherwise have been cited. Every hero image was fetched and looked at before it was captioned; one whose file description did not match its contents was discarded rather than printed. Figures we could not stand behind are flagged in place or absent, and **corrections to our own record appear on p14 and p23.** Full source lists appear on the desk pages.